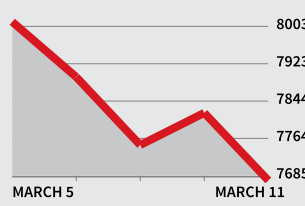


the hindu businessline.

SENSEX 76863.71 (-1342.27)



IN FOCUS

	LATEST	CHANGE
Nifty 50	23866.85	-394.75
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	21.10	-0.37
US Dollar (in ₹)	92.04	+0.24
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	159588.00	+41
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	266010.00	-4934

BULL RUN FADES.

Copper prices have come under pressure on a stronger dollar, rising energy prices and the war against Iran **p8**



TECHNOPHILE.

Nothing 4a is a stylish smartphone with an edgy design and clutter-free user experience **p6**

BENGALURU - CHENNAI - COIMBATORE - HUBBALLI - HYDERABAD - KOCHI - KOLKATA - MADURAI - MALAPPURAM - MANGALURU - MUMBAI - NOIDA - THIRUVANANTHAPURAM - TIRUCHIRAPALLI - VIJAYAWADA - VISAKHAPATNAM

Regd. TN/ARD/14/2012-2014, RNI No. 55320/94

QUICKLY.

ROAD TO NOWHERE
LPG price surge hits autorickshaw, taxi drivers



Bengaluru: The mobility sector could be the next to feel the pinch of a surge in LPG costs as supply concerns mount due to the ongoing conflict in West Asia. In Bengaluru, autorickshaw drivers raised concerns as rising fuel prices are threatening livelihoods and urban transport availability. Over the past 10 days, LPG prices have surged by nearly ₹30 from around ₹55. **p2**

INVESTMENT BOOST
Rare earths, battery parts join FDI fast-track list

New Delhi: The government's recent decision to fast-track FDI applications from entities in land bordering countries (LBC), including China, within 60 days in specific sectors will extend to advanced battery components, rare earth permanent magnets and rare earth processing, officials from the Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade (DPIIT) said. **p3**

Trump announces first US refinery in 50 years with Reliance on board

ENERGETIC. America First Refining facility to process 60 m barrels/year of light shale oil

Richa Mishra
Janaki Krishnan
Hyderabad/Mumbai

US President Donald Trump said America First Refining was opening the first US oil refinery in 50 years in Texas, and indicated that India's Reliance Industries would also be investing in it.

In a post on social media platform Truth Social, Trump said: "Today I am proud to announce that America First Refining is opening the first new US oil refinery in 50 years in Brownsville Texas. This is a historic \$300 billion deal — the biggest in US history..."

THANKS RELIANCE

He went on to thank "our partners in India, and their largest privately-held energy company, Reliance, for this tremendous investment".

Confirming the construction of the oil refinery, America First Refining, in a statement, said that in February it had received "a 9-figure investment from a global supermajor at a 10-figure valuation". It added that it had



STRATEGIC DEALS. Reliance Industries is not the only partner in the project, and there are other companies investing in it

signed a "binding 20-year offtake term sheet with the same global supermajor that secures commitments to purchase, process and distribute American-produced energy exclusively sourced from American shale oil."

PRODUCTION CAPACITY

The statement, however, did not disclose any names, but said the facility will have capacity to process 60 million barrels per year of US light shale oil. Its strategic location at a deepwater port would enable easy distribu-

tion to the domestic and international markets. America First Refining said it expects to break ground for the refinery in the second quarter of 2026.

Sources *businessline* spoke to indicated that RIL's involvement in the project was still in the works and that the details were in the process of being worked out. The final agreement is yet to be signed, said multiple sources with knowledge of the development. RIL is not the only partner in the project, and there are other companies

investing in it, the sources added. An e-mail sent to RIL seeking confirmation of its investment and details of the project did not receive a response. The company has not made an official statement.

INDIA-US TRADE

RIL's investment in the US energy sector is seen as a significant component in the India-US trade negotiations. US has a shortage of refining capacity and RIL, as the world's largest refiner, can play a critical role here, analysts say.

The company also stands to benefit from the deal. The US is a market for petchem and petroleum products, and RIL has a long-term contract to import ethane from the US. In his post, Trump called the investment the largest in US history and a "massive win for American workers, energy and the great people of South Texas".

The refinery is expected to fuel US markets, boost energy production and "deliver billions of dollars in economic impact", according to Trump.

Nifty slips to 10-month low amid war woes

Anupama Ghosh
Mumbai

The markets suffered a sharp, broad-based sell-off on Wednesday, with the Nifty50 closing at its lowest level in nearly 10 months. Escalating geopolitical tensions in West Asia, a firming dollar and persistent foreign institutional selling battered investor confidence.

The Sensex plunged 1,342.27 points, or 1.72 per cent, to close at 76,863.71, while the Nifty50 shed 394.75 points, or 1.63 per cent, to end at 23,866.85. It slipped below the psychological 24,000 mark for the first time since the record highs seen at the start of 2026.

Nifty Financial Services was among the hardest hit sectoral indices, dropping 2.32 per cent while Nifty Bank fell 2.13 per cent, erasing the entire gains of the previous session.

Nifty Midcap 100 lost 1.25 per cent and Nifty Next 50 declined 1.08 per cent. Nifty Smallcap 100 showed relative resilience, shedding just 0.36 per cent. Auto was the worst-hit sector, losing over 3 per cent. Selective buying in pharma and oil & gas provided limited support.

India's energy supplies are secure, says govt

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

The government asserted that emergency measures, including directing refineries and petrochemical complexes to maximise LPG production, and invocation of the Essential Commodities Act and Petroleum Products (Maintenance of Production, Storage and Supply) Order from March 5, had helped boost India's LPG production by 25 per cent.

The government also underlined that 70 per cent of India's crude imports are now being routed outside the Strait of Hormuz and that energy supplies are secure.

HOUSEHOLD USE

Sujata Sharma, Joint Secretary, Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas, said the entire domestic LPG production is being directed towards household consumers.

She said that the government, on March 8, directed all domestic or SEZ oil-refining companies to ensure that the entire production of C3 and C4 streams, including propane, butane and propylene, is utilised for LPG production. "Due to this, domestic LPG production

increased 25 per cent," she added, without offering more details on the volumes produced.

On Monday, government sources said LPG production was up 10 per cent.

LPG OUTPUT

India's average daily LPG production stood around 34,613 tonnes in October 2025, declining to 34,533 tonnes in November.

However, it rose to 35,968 tonnes in December 2025 and to 37,355 tonnes in January this year. February 2026 numbers are yet to be published. If we take the latest available (January 2026) average daily production as the base, India's LPG average per day output has risen to roughly 46,694 tonnes.

On LNG, Sharma said India's cumulative natural gas consumption is around 189 million standard cubic meters per day (mscmd), of which around 97.5 mscmd is domestically produced and the remaining 91.5 mscmd is imported. Of this, 47.4 mscmd of supply is affected due to *force majeure*.

The situation is challenging at the global level, but India's energy supplies are in control, said Sharma.

Also read **p2**

SCAN TO KNOW MORE



SBI MUTUAL FUND
A PARTNER FOR LIFE

ANY TIME IS A GOOD TIME FOR MULTI ASSET ALLOCATION FUNDS

A fund for all market conditions with Equity, Fixed Income, Gold, Silver, etc.

DIVERSIFICATION

Invests in at least 3 asset classes to manage risk and seek growth in various market conditions.

CONVENIENCE

Offers a convenient way to gain exposure to multiple asset classes in one fund.

TAX EFFICIENCY

Provides equity / non-equity taxation benefits depending on the asset allocation.

AN INVESTOR EDUCATION AND AWARENESS INITIATIVE BY SBI MUTUAL FUND.

Investors should deal only with registered Mutual Funds, details of which can be verified on the SEBI website (<https://www.sebi.gov.in>) under Intermediaries/Market Infrastructure Institutions'. Please refer to website of mutual funds for process for completing one-time KYC (Know Your Customer) including process for change in address, phone number, bank details etc. Investors may lodge complaints on <https://scores.sebi.gov.in> against registered intermediaries if they are unsatisfied with their responses. SCORES facilitates you to lodge your complaint online with SEBI and subsequently view its status.

For more information contact your MFD/RIA | Visit: www.sbimf.com | Follow us: [f](#) [X](#) [v](#) [i](#) [n](#) [w](#)

Mutual Fund investments are subject to market risks, read all scheme related documents carefully.

‘Diversification strategy has paid off’

NAVIGATING STRESS. India imports crude from around 40 nations; 2 more crude cargoes on the way: Govt

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

Assuring crude oil supplies for India, which consumes 5.5 million barrels per day, are secure, the government on Wednesday emphasised that its diversification strategy ensured that the currently contracted cargoes exceed the import volume that came through the Strait of Hormuz.

Sujata Sharma, Joint Secretary, Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas, said that India now imports crude from around 40 countries. Consequently, about 70 per cent of crude imports are coming from routes outside the Strait of Hormuz compared with about 55 per cent earlier.

“Two additional crude cargoes are already on the way and will further strengthen the crude oil supply position. Refineries are



COMFORTABLE LEVELS. If the current cargo movements continue, total Russian crude arrivals for the full month could reach close to 2 mb/d or potentially even exceed that level

operating at very high capacity utilisation levels, in some cases even above 100 per cent,” she added.

RUSSIAN CARGOES

Besides, India’s crude oil stocks got further boost as the US waived certain oil-related sanctions on Russia paving way for the world’s third-largest consumer to top up supplies, which are expected to hit 2 million bar-

rels per day (mb/d) or even higher in March 2026.

Sumit Ritolia, Lead Research Analyst for Refining & Modelling, Kpler, a global real-time data and analytics provider, told *businessline*, “Russian crude into India is already estimated at around 1.5 mb/d, reflecting the strong pace of inflows. Looking ahead, if the current shipment schedules and cargo movements continue, total

Russian crude arrivals for the full month could reach close to 2 mb/d, or potentially even exceed that level.”

Russian crude imports into India have accelerated significantly in recent days. Earlier in February, prior to the escalation of geopolitical tensions, expectations for Russian crude imports into India were estimated at around 800-1,000 thousand b/d, he said. Following the developments and the US allowing flexibility for India to continue purchasing Russian barrels, trade flows have picked up considerably, enabling India to import volumes well above the earlier baseline levels.

LPG PRODUCTION

Another operational factor for refineries is LPG production, Ritolia pointed out. “Domestic refineries have the flexibility to optimise LPG output by shifting feedstocks away from petro-

chemical production toward LPG recovery and by adjusting unit operations to maximise yields,” he added.

While crude oil and refined product supply positions remain comfortable, LPG availability will likely be the key area to monitor in the coming weeks, something that Kpler has also been highlighting over the past week as an important factor for India’s short-term energy balance, he emphasised.

The government has been pushing for more LPG production by refiners, considering its crude oil and products supply position is comfortable.

The steady inflow of Russian barrels, combined with additional sourcing from the US and West Africa, will help ensure that India remains well supplied with crude, despite the uncertainties surrounding the Strait of Hormuz and broader geopolitical tensions.

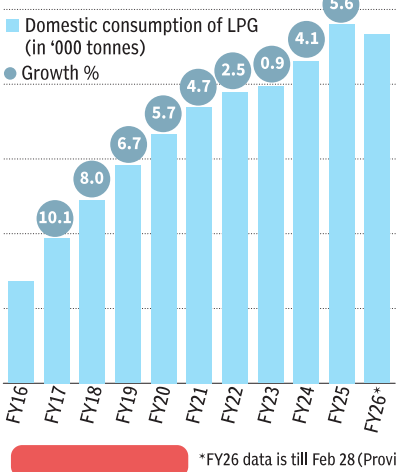
VISUALLY.

Compiled by **Sourashis Banerjee, Sindhu Hariharan** | Graphic: **Visveswaran V**

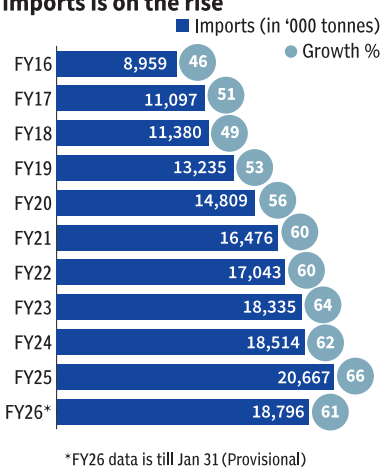
Growing vulnerabilities

With gradual increase in the domestic consumption of liquefied petroleum gas (LPG), import dependence is also growing. While about 46 per cent of domestic demand was met by imports in FY16, this has gone up to 61 per cent in FY26. This import dependence raises strategic vulnerabilities in India’s energy security, especially in cases like the present West Asia conflict, as India sources 80-90 per cent of its LPG imports from that region

Domestic consumption of LPG increasing at a slow pace

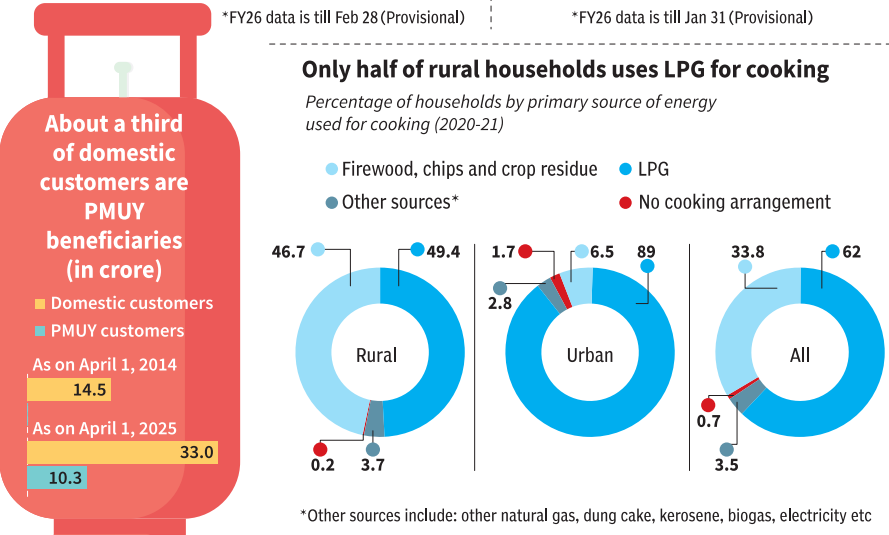


But share of domestic LPG consumption being met by imports is on the rise

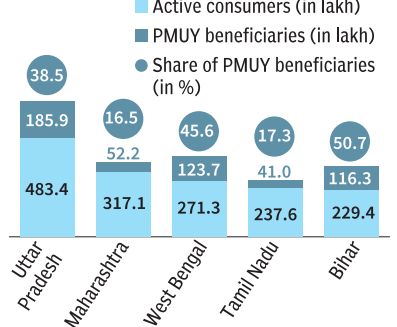


Only half of rural households uses LPG for cooking

Percentage of households by primary source of energy used for cooking (2020-21)

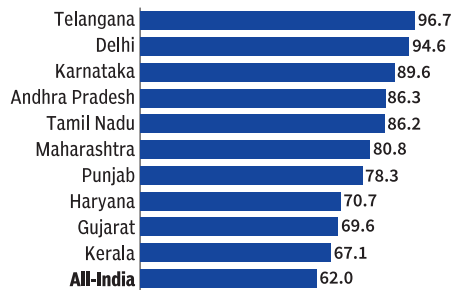


Share of PMUY beneficiaries is higher in low-income States



However, southern States have higher adoption of LPG for cooking

% of households using LPG for cooking among top States (urban + rural - 2020-21)



Source: PPAC, Multiple Indicator Survey in India - NSS 78th round

Electronics supply chain stakeholders brace for a margin hit

Aishwarya Kumar
Bengaluru

A sustained rise in crude oil prices could begin to pressure the consumer electronics supply chain through higher petrochemical input costs.

Key plastic materials, such as acrylonitrile butadiene styrene (ABS) and polypropylene, derived from crude and widely used in device casings, have seen prices rise 45-50 per cent, with suppliers increasing rates by ₹23-25 per kg.

Reliance Industries (RIL), the largest producer and supplier of polypropylene

(PP) in India, recently raised its list prices by ₹23-25 per kg, according to an industry source who requested anonymity. Manufacturers have three-five months of inventory.

The Strait of Hormuz handles roughly a fifth of global oil and LNG shipments. Industry executives said the consumer electronics and IoT segments operate on razor-thin margins. “A \$15 smart plug cannot absorb a 12 per cent jump in plastic costs,” said a source.

PUSHED TO THE BRINK

A source in the contract manufacturing industry said the impact may begin to

show if the situation persists for “three-four” months.

The source added that other raw materials are also seeing cost pressures. “Aluminium, used in consumer electronics and aerospace components, is seeing a 10-12 per cent increase in prices. This will impact margins in the coming quarter,” they said.

Abhilash Kumar M, an independent technology analyst, said the global electronics and hardware industry is already vulnerable due to supply pressures in the semiconductor ecosystem. “The rapid growth in AI infrastructure has resulted in supply shortages in the



memory chip industry. If crude prices remain elevated for a prolonged period, it could impact the broader economy, weakening consumer spending and ultimately affecting demand for electronics,” he said.

Saurav Kumar Singh, CEO and Co-founder of Elecbits, said the industry could face a double hit from rising energy

costs and logistics disruptions. “Every electronics shipment is built on petrochemical derivatives. PCB laminates, plastic enclosures, connector housings and conformal coatings are all directly tied to crude and natural gas pricing,” he said. Elecbits, which works with over 200 clients, is already seen quoting uncertainty of six-eight weeks due to raw material volatility, Singh added.

He noted that manufacturers are trying to mitigate the impact by locking in supplier contracts, diversifying sourcing geographies and optimising product design to reduce material waste.

Borosil’s Jaipur glass units feel the heat of war

Our Bureau
Ahmedabad

The fallout from the ongoing West Asian conflict is hitting India’s energy-intensive industries, with Borosil on Wednesday reporting LPG shortages that have forced a temporary suspension of its borosilicate glass furnace and reduced capacity at its opal glass units at Jaipur in Rajasthan.

The disruption follows a *force majeure* notice from oil marketing companies (OMCs).

According to a regulatory filing, the company stated, “While production at the Borosilicate Glass Furnace has been temporarily suspended, the Opal Glass Furnaces have been operating at lower capacities. We are actively coordinating with OMCs and government authorities to secure LPG supply and ensure continuity of production to the extent feasible.”

“We are evaluating the impact arising from the ongoing disruption in the supply of LPG,” the company added.

Surge in LPG prices, gas supply crunch threaten livelihoods of auto & taxi drivers

Jyoti Banthia
Aishwarya Kumar
Bengaluru



MOBILITY CONCERNS. Bengaluru has 2-2.5 lakh autorickshaws, of which 70,000-80,000 run on LPG and 80,000-1,00,000 on CNG

The mobility sector could be the next to feel the pinch of a surge in LPG cost, as supply concerns mount due to the ongoing conflict in West Asia. In Bengaluru, autorickshaw drivers raise concerns as rising fuel prices threaten livelihoods and urban transport availability.

Over the past 10 days, LPG prices have surged by nearly ₹30 from around ₹55. CNG prices continue to increase amid thinning fuel banks, creating anxiety among drivers.

According to Tanveer Pasha, president of the Auto Union Federation, the city’s mobility network relies heavily on LPG and CNG-powered vehicles. Bengaluru has 2-2.5 lakh autorickshaws, of which 70,000-80,000 run on LPG and 80,000-1,00,000 operate on CNG. Electric autos account for only 15,000-20,000 of the vehicles.

“Fuel supplies in

Bengaluru are severely disrupted. We are facing a serious crisis with both LPG and CNG availability. The Central government must step forward and direct State governments to find effective solutions — both to control rising prices and address the worsening supply shortage,” Pasha said.

FEELING THE HEAT

“If auto and taxi drivers do not receive adequate fuel supply, public transport will be severely affected — impacting not only daily commuters but also the liveli-

hoods of thousands of auto and taxi drivers,” he added.

Drivers say the rapid rise in LPG prices is already beginning to dent their incomes. “So far, there is no issue with CNG, but with LPG there are some issues. The prices have gone up. We haven’t seen such quick price hikes in the past few years,” said a Rapido driver. Unions also said some drivers are beginning to limit the number of rides they accept in order to cushion the impact of higher fuel expenses.

Delivery workers associated with food platforms

could also face challenges if restaurants and cloud kitchens experience LPG shortages, reducing food preparation capacity and order volumes.

NO DISRUPTION SO FAR

Despite the concerns raised by unions and drivers, ride-hailing platforms said they had not yet seen any disruption. “So far, we haven’t received any concerns from driver partners. However, we remain closely engaged with the driver community and continuously work with them to address any issues that may arise. If we do receive feedback or complaints, we will ensure that they are resolved promptly and provide the necessary support. At this stage, we have also not observed any impact on pricing,” said a spokesperson from Moving Tech, which operates the Namma Yatri platform.

“We are not seeing any significant disruption to auto or cab supply on the platform despite reports of an LPG or CNG shortage,” a Rapido spokesperson said.

Restaurants, hotels seek minimum assured allocation of LPG supplies

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

Restaurants and hotels have sought minimum assured allocation of commercial LPG cylinder supplies. This comes at a time when industry players across key cities are facing shortages amid the ongoing West Asia conflict.

“A prolonged disruption in LPG supply to restaurants and commercial kitchens could lead to the non-availability of food for millions of citizens who rely on these establishments for their daily meals, including students in hostels, individuals without adequate housing and busy working professionals. Restaurants and food service businesses are integral to India’s daily food supply chain.

Ensuring continuity of LPG supply will help maintain food availability while safeguarding livelihoods across the sector,” said Kumar Rajgopal, CEO, Retailers Association of India.

Echoing the sentiment, Anurag Katriar, Founder, Indigo Hospitality, and former President, NRAI, said, “The industry has limited alternatives. Players are looking at induction and electrical equipment but can use it only to make some dishes. Also, restaurants are truncating menus.”

REQUEST FOR AID

Arjun Baljee, President of Royal Orchid Hotels, pointed out that only larger establishments have the ability to leverage on electrical cooking equipment infrastructure and smaller and

medium-size players rely heavily on LPG. “We have implemented contingency measures like diversifying suppliers, optimising kitchen fuel usage and using electrical cooking equipment,” he added.

In a statement, KB Kachru, President, Hotel Association of India (HAI), and Chairman-South Asia, Radisson Hotel Group, added that irregular and non-availability of LPG will adversely impact the sector.

“As gas supply is critical to the operation of the hospitality sector, we urge the government’s special consideration to treat our industry as an essential service and ensure supply without disruption to this sector, a vital pillar of employment generation and economic development,” he said.

Rise in raw material costs pinches Tiruppur textile industry

T E Raja Simhan
Chennai



FADING MARGINS. Dyeing units have increased processing charges: ₹10 per kg for bleaching and light colours, ₹15 per kg for medium colours, and ₹20 per kg for dark colours

ment manufacturing costs nearly 5 per cent.

INPUT COSTS

The Tiruppur dyeing industry has announced an increase in charges following a steep rise in the prices of essential chemicals and fuels used in textile processing.

According to industry representatives, polyester prices had also increased

sharply following a rise in yarn costs, with prices going up by about ₹14 per kg or 20 per cent.

P Gandhirajan, President of the Tiruppur Dyers Association and MD of Tiruppur-based Atul Process, said the conflict had disrupted supply chains and pushed up prices of major raw materials used in dyeing and processing.

Consequently, dyeing units had been forced to increase processing charges: ₹10 per kg for bleaching and light colours, ₹15 per kg for medium colours and ₹20 per kg for dark colours, he said.

Gandhirajan said the suspension of commercial and industrial gas supply and a rise in the cost of firewood used by dyeing units had added to the burden.

However, exporters said passing on costs to international buyers will be difficult. “It is very difficult to increase prices. However, due

penses,” he added. Titanium dioxide, a crucial derivative of crude oil, is one of the key ingredients in paint manufacturing.

RAW MATERIAL COST

Amit Purohit, Vice-President, Elara Capital, said paint companies will pass on the increase in raw material cost to customers.

Usually, paint companies hold about two months of raw material inventory and pass on high input cost to consumers in two-three quarters, he added.

Rajesh Singla, CEO & Fund Manager, Alpha AIF, said while the sharp reversal in crude prices has temporarily lifted sentiment in paint stocks, investors will continue to watch global oil trends and demand conditions to assess the sustainability of this rally.

Apart from input cost expectations, he added paint companies will benefit from strong structural demand drivers such as housing activity, urbanisation and renovation cycles.

businessline.

Disclaimer: Readers are requested to verify & make appropriate enquiries to satisfy themselves about the veracity of an advertisement before responding to any published in this newspaper. THG PUBLISHING PVT LTD., the Publisher & Owner of this newspaper, does not vouch for the authenticity of any advertisement or advertiser or for any of the advertiser’s products and/or services. In no event can the Owner, Publisher, Printer, Editor, Director/s, Employees of this newspaper/company be held responsible/liability in any manner whatsoever for any claims and/or damages for advertisements in this newspaper.

QUICKLY.

Jaishankar speaks with
Iran, Russia, France, EU



New Delhi: External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar and his Iranian counterpart Seyed Abbas Araghchi discussed the consequences of the disruptions in the movement of oil tankers in the Strait of Hormuz in their phone conversation on Tuesday, the Iranian government has said. Jaishankar also spoke to Russian Foreign Minister Sergey Lavrov, European Union's Foreign Policy chief Kaja Kallas and French Foreign Minister Jean-Noel Barrot on Wednesday on the West Asia conflict and its repercussions. "Referring to Iran's principled approach to safeguarding shipping security in the Persian Gulf, Iran's Foreign Minister reminded that the insecure situation and problems arising for shipping in the Persian Gulf are a result of the aggressive and destabilising actions of the US, and the international community must hold the US accountable for this situation," said a readout issued by Iran's Foreign Ministry on Wednesday. **OUR BUREAU**

Rare earths, battery parts join FDI fast-track list for land border nations

INVESTING IN INDIA. However, the processes for security and political clearances will remain in place: DPIIT

Amiti Sen
New Delhi

The government's recent decision to fast-track FDI applications from entities in land bordering countries (LBC), including China, within 60 days in specific sectors will extend to advanced battery components, rare earth permanent magnets and rare earth processing, officials from the Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade (DPIIT) have said.

On Tuesday, sectors such as capital goods, electronics and solar cells were listed by the government for favourable treatment, but an official list of such items is being compiled and will be notified, officials said at a media briefing on Wednesday.

LIBERALISED RULES

The new liberalised rules, which permit investments through the automatic route for entities linked to LBC countries with up to 10 per cent non-controlling beneficial ownership, will also hold



UNDER PRESS NOTE 3. Any investment from countries sharing a land border with India is allowed only through the government approval route **REUTERS**

for applications already under process, subject to furnishing of relevant information by the investee, officials noted.

However, these norms will not apply to entities registered in China/Hong Kong or other countries sharing land borders with India.

"All the restrictions for investors from LBCs are still applicable. There is no relaxation so far as entities or investors in LBCs are concerned. This relaxation is only for entities in non-LBCs and having beneficial owners from LBCs below 10 per cent

and non-controlling stake... so there are no relaxations so far as investments from LBCs are concerned," DPIIT Joint Secretary Jai Prakash Shivahare said.

Under Press Note 3 (PN3 of 2020), any investment from countries sharing a land border with India — including China, Pakistan, Bangladesh, Myanmar, Nepal, Bhutan and Afghanistan — is allowed only through the government approval route.

PN3 REQUIREMENTS

The easing of PN3 require-

ments has been brought about following discussions with stakeholders, including high-profile institutional investors such as BlackRock, which had reportedly sought the easing of PN3.

Currently, approximately 600 applications are pending under PN3, said DPIIT Secretary Amardeep Singh Bhatia.

Many of these applications will now fall into two streamlined categories — those below the 10 per cent threshold and those eligible for the expedited mechanism.

If applications that are already under process qualify for the 10 per cent limit, the applicants may proceed with their investments immediately after the official notification of the new rules, after filing the necessary disclosures, Bhatia said.

Existing applicants who want to apply for the new expedited mechanism have the option to resubmit their applications.

Asked about the sanctity of the shorter timelines, Bhatia said a specific framework

had been established to ensure the 60-day timeline is strictly honoured, offering much-needed certainty to potential investors.

SECURITY CLEARANCES

Although some steps have been done away with in the expedited process, broadly the process of security and political clearances will remain in place, the Secretary said.

The selection of the sectors that will qualify for fast-tracking is based on the need to increase manufacturing in specific sectors in India, Bhatia said, adding that the list could be expanded in the future.

"We need manufacturing to take place in India, whether it is a sewing machine or whether it is an Industry 4.0 machine which are assembling solar cells, or whether it is switchgear and so on. So, these are areas in which we feel there is a large scope of partnership, and joint ventures... But having said that, this is not a watertight compartment," Bhatia said.

Retail inflation likely to edge above 3% in February

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi



The Statistics Ministry is set to release February's retail inflation data on Thursday

Retail inflation, measured by the Consumer Price Index (CPI), is expected to have climbed past 3 per cent in February, though some economists anticipate a higher print of 4 per cent.

Experts further warn that the economic fallout from the ongoing war is likely to surface in the March data, to be released in April.

The Statistics Ministry is set to release February's retail inflation data on Thursday. Following a 2.7 per cent print in January, this will be the second CPI report of the 2024 series.

"We expect a further climb in headline CPI inflation to 3.1 per cent in February from 2.7 per cent, as the scale of disinflation in food (including vegetables, pulses, etc.) continues to ease, while precious metal price pressures remain firm," Radhika Rao, Senior Economist at DBS Bank, said. Elara Capital's Economist Garima Kapoor expects the number at 3.35 per cent, while Rajeev Sharan, Head of Research, Brickwork Ratings, expects headline inflation of 3.5-4 per cent. Rao said that while

pipeline price risks are being monitored, specifically regarding the recent hike in LPG prices and government anti-hoarding measures, an immediate increase in retail fuel prices remains unlikely.

CRUDE COSTS

Sharan of Brickwork Ratings said crude oil prices are once again carrying a conflict premium, with Brent volatility feeding directly into sector costs and consumer inflation.

"Empirical analysis shows that a 10 per cent rise in crude can lift headline CPI inflation by 20 basis points in the short run," he said.

"The impact of elevated crude prices will be reflected in the March CPI inflation numbers," Sharan concluded.

India slams attack on Thai ship transiting Strait of Hormuz en route to Kandla port

Our Bureau/Agencies
New Delhi

India has strongly criticised the reported attack on Thai ship *Mayuree Naree*, bound for Kandla port in Gujarat, in the Strait of Hormuz on Wednesday.

"We have seen reports about the attack on a Thai ship, *Mayuree Naree*, in the Strait of Hormuz on March 11. The ship was bound for Kandla in India. India deplores the fact that commercial shipping is being made a target of military attacks in the ongoing conflict in West Asia," per a statement issued by the Ministry of External Affairs on Wednesday.

Precious lives, including of Indian citizens, have been lost in such attacks in the



UNSAFE WATERS. The Thailand-flagged cargo ship *Mayuree Naree*, engulfed in black smoke in the Strait of Hormuz **REUTERS**

earlier phase of the conflict, the intensity and lethality of which only seems to be in-

creasing. "India reiterates that targeting commercial shipping and endangering in-

nocent civilian crew members, or otherwise impeding freedom of navigation and commerce, should be avoided," it emphasised.

The United Kingdom Maritime Trade Operations (UKMTO) said later, referring to the incident, that the fire had been extinguished and there was no environmental impact. Necessary crew remained on the vessel.

Earlier, the Japan-flagged container ship *One Majesty* had sustained minor damage from an unknown projectile 25 nautical miles northwest of Ras Al Khaimah in the UAE, two maritime security sources said. A third vessel, a bulk carrier, was also hit by an unknown projectile approximately 50 miles northwest of Dubai, maritime security firms said.

Manali Petro suspends operations at one of its Chennai units after CPCL halts propylene supply

Our Bureau
Chennai

Manali Petrochemicals Ltd (MPL) has temporarily suspended operations at one of its plants in Chennai after Chennai Petroleum Corporation Ltd (CPCL) stopped supplying propylene with immediate effect, citing a directive from the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas (MoPNG).

In a disclosure to stock exchanges, MPL said it had suspended operations at Plant-1 in Manali from Thursday, following the complete cessation of propylene supply from CPCL.

Propylene is the primary and indispensable feedstock for MPL's manufacturing operations, and the company

sources it exclusively from CPCL. However, MPL said Plant-2 continues to operate using available feedstock inventory, and any further developments will be disclosed to stock exchanges as required.

The company termed the shutdown a *force majeure* event, stating that it arose from a sovereign regulatory directive issued by the Government of India and is beyond its control.

LPG PRODUCTION

According to the company, the stoppage of propylene supply follows an order issued by the MoPNG, directing CPCL to prioritise the production of LPG from crude oil processed at its refinery.

The directive mandates

that crude oil processed at CPCL's refinery should go exclusively and, on a priority basis, towards LPG production in order to ensure domestic fuel availability and strengthen national energy security.

Following the order, CPCL has been directed to discontinue processing crude oil for other downstream petrochemical derivatives, including propylene, for the duration of the directive.

The government's move comes amid significant disruptions to international crude oil and petrochemical supply chains caused by the ongoing geopolitical conflict in West Asia, the company said.

MPL said it is currently evaluating the implications

of the supply disruption and is taking necessary steps to manage its commitments to stakeholders.

"The likely impact of the *force majeure*, which is currently an ongoing event, cannot be estimated at this point of time," the company said in its filing.

It added that the situation is being closely monitored, and any material developments will be communicated to the stock exchanges in line with regulatory requirements.

Manali Petrochemicals manufactures propylene oxide (PO) and related petrochemical products, which are used in a range of industries including polyols, pharmaceuticals, construction materials, and speciality chemicals.

SBI, MUFG ink pact to facilitate cross-border capital flows

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The State Bank of India and Japan's MUFG Bank have signed a strategic partnership agreement to advance bilateral financial collaboration and strengthen the India-Japan economic corridor.

The agreement aims to facilitate cross-border capital flows, create new synergistic financing opportunities and support sustainable economic growth across two of Asia's largest economies, SBI said in a statement.

The alliance will support Japanese corporates expanding in India as well as Indian enterprises pursuing international growth, including

entry into Japan and other global markets.

Under the agreement, SBI and MUFG will explore collaboration in structuring and financing projects with a specific focus on sectors such as M&A, aviation and real estate finance.

The banks will also co-operate on M&A advisory, trade finance and retail banking solutions, facilitating Japanese corporate-linked potential inbound and outbound transactions.

Both banks will help facilitate the introduction of Indian mid-corporates and MSMEs to Japanese corporate clients, identifying financing opportunities that deepen transaction-level collaboration.

Settlement, compounding charges push up SEBI's income to ₹2,713 crore in FY25

Akshata Gorde
Mumbai

Settlement and compounding of enforcement cases emerged a major revenue source for the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) in 2024-25, with receipts under the framework jumping nearly eight-fold to ₹814.55 crore from ₹104.13 crore in the previous year, according to the regulator's audited annual statement of accounts.

The sharp rise in settlements contributed to SEBI's total income increasing to ₹2,713 crore in FY25 from ₹2,075 crore in FY24, a growth of about 31 per cent.

The regulator's capital base also strengthened, with its corpus or capital fund rising to ₹7,234.66 crore as of March 31, 2025, compared with ₹5,572.82 crore a year earlier.

The accounts show that settlement and compounding receipts were one of the largest individual inflows for the year. As per the statement, SEBI received ₹814.55 crore towards settlement/ compounding charges during the year as against ₹104.13 crore in the previous year.

Under SEBI's settlement framework, entities facing enforcement proceedings can resolve matters without admission or denial of guilt

by paying a settlement amount and complying with specified conditions.

PENALTY RECOVERIES

The accounts also note that a portion of the enforcement-related collections is transferred to the government. "In terms of Section 151A of SEBI (Amendment) Act 2002, the Board remits penalties collected... to the Consolidated Fund of India," the report said.

Apart from settlements, the regulator recorded ₹10.95 crore towards penalties during the year, up from ₹2.98 crore in the previous year.

SEBI's income from investments also increased



during the year to ₹325.47 crore from ₹192.41 crore in FY24, reflecting the growing size of its investment pool.

The regulator's investments remain largely in low-risk instruments. The balance sheet shows ₹2,857 crore invested in government securities and ₹2,215 crore placed in deposits with

scheduled banks, along with ₹30 crore invested in the National Centre for Financial Education.

These investments form a substantial portion of the regulator's financial assets and provide a steady stream of income through interest and returns.

AUDIT OBSERVATIONS

However, the Comptroller and Auditor General, which audited the accounts, flagged certain internal control and reconciliation issues.

Among them were discrepancies relating to lease deposits and asset records. The audit report said "there were unreconciled differences in the lease deposits as

reflected on the liability side of the financial statements and lease deposit liability calculated based on executed lease agreements".

It also pointed out that in the physical verification report "certain assets were marked 'disposed of' but were not removed or discarded from the books".

Despite these observations, the overall financial position of the regulator strengthened during the year, supported by higher income and a larger corpus.

The spike in settlements suggests that enforcement actions and negotiated case closures played a significant role in boosting SEBI's revenues in FY25.

APPOINTMENT

INDIAN INSTITUTE OF BANKING & FINANCE
Email: hrd@iibf.org.in | Tel. No.: 022 6850 7074

REQUIRES

CHIEF TECHNOLOGY OFFICER
on contract basis

Indian Institute of Banking & Finance (IIBF) invites applications for recruitment of the above position. Please visit our website www.iibf.org.in under "Career" tab for further details.

Mumbai
10/03/2026

Chief Executive Officer

COCHIN INTERNATIONAL AIRPORT LIMITED
CIAL/COMM/SNW/61 (E-Tender No: 2026_CIAL_841243) 12/03/2026

TENDER NOTICE

Item rate E-tenders are invited from reputed contractors for SITC of Software Patch & Asset Management Solution at Cochin International Airport.

Name of Work	Estimate Amount	EMD	Completion Period
SITC of Software Patch & Asset Management Solution	Rs. 74.88 Lakhs + GST	Rs. 2 Lakhs	3 Months

Interested firms may register themselves on the online E-Tendering portal <https://etenders.kerala.gov.in>. Tender document will be available for download from 13/03/2026. For eligibility criteria and other details, visit our website www.cial.aero

Sd/-
MANAGING DIRECTOR

TATA POWER
(Corporate Contracts Department)

The Tata Power Company Limited, Smart Center of Procurement Excellence, 3rd Floor, Sahar Receiving Station, Near Hotel Leela, Sahar Airport Road Andheri (E), Mumbai 400 058, Maharashtra, India
(Board Line: 022-67173917) CIN: L28920MH1919PLC000567

NOTICE INVITING TENDER (NIT)

The Tata Power Company Limited invites tender from eligible vendors for the following tender package (Two-part Bidding) in Mumbai.
(A). Package A: EPC Package (Without Civil) for replacement of 245 kV GIS at Salsette receiving station and Package B: EPC Package (Without Civil) for Installation of new 220 kV Outdoor GIS Substation at Powai receiving Station. (Package Ref: **CC26AM011**).
(B). EPC of 400 kV GIS & associated equipment along with Civil Works for 400 kV GIS Receiving Stations at Dharavi & Ghatkopar in Mumbai. (Package Ref: **CC27AA001**).
(C) Construction of boundary wall at Badlapur and civil works for GIS plot (Package Re: **CC25TP064**)

Interested and eligible bidders to submit Tender Fee and Authorization Letter before **1500 hrs. Tuesday, 24th March 2026**.
For detailed NIT, please visit Tender section on website <https://www.tatapower.com>. Also, all future corrigendum's if any, to the said tender will be published on Tender section of above website (Tata Power → Business Associates → Tender Documents) only.

Ethanol drive

Mandating E20 petrol calls for checks and balances

In an interesting coincidence, the Centre issued a directive mandating 20 per cent ethanol use in high octane petrol, just days before the Iran war broke out. To place in perspective the import of this step which will come into effect from April 1, petrol substitution has translated into savings of ₹1.4 lakh crore in foreign exchange since 2014. Ethanol blending can make a big difference to India’s petroleum imports of at least \$150 billion, at current over-the-roof prices. But the virtues and demerits of ethanol go beyond savings in the import bill.

By all accounts, ethanol blending of about 20 per cent has already been achieved. What the latest directive seeks to do is to formalise the arrangement across petrol pumps by also mandating the use of premium petrol (with a research octane number of 95) in the blend. Ethanol too has a high octane content; a superior blend is perhaps expected to smoothen the combustion process and allay consumer fears over ethanol damaging vehicle engines. But consumers should be allowed to make informed choices. Petrol pumps should offer a bouquet of options at various price points, while incentivising the shift to E20 or more. Consumers who wish to opt for less or no ethanol in their petrol should be given the option of paying more. Meanwhile, car and two-wheeler makers need to come out upfront with clear product specifications on how their engines are equipped to deal with ethanol’s supposedly corrosive properties. Ethanol’s lower calorific value reduces mileage, and to that extent raises petrol use.

Ethanol produces lower tailpipe greenhouse gas emissions, but the same cannot readily be said for the emissions over its entire product cycle. Besides, emissions from ethanol-blended petrol are not free of sulphur, nitrogen and other toxic chemicals. The environment-friendliness of ethanol depends a lot on the feedstock used. Recent research explains how ethanol is resource efficient perhaps only when no additional land, water or fertilizer is used. There is also the issue of diverting land from food crops. Fifty lakh tonnes of rice and 40 lakh tonnes of sugar would be used in India annually to support current levels of ethanol output. Therefore, agriculture waste, molasses, waste oils, fats and greases are a better feedstock option than using sugarcane, maize or rice. Maize is urea-intensive, even if it demands less water than rice or sugarcane. However, ethanol can be considered as a clean fuel option if product cycle issues are considered — including land and water scarcity, and food security.

It is also to be noted that electric vehicles are becoming viable by the day on account of falling battery costs and improved efficiency. To be sure, the product cycle emissions issues as well as import intensity of the process are germane issues here as well. The green transport transition should combine both ethanol blending and EVs judiciously — without lobbies driving the process. Domestic availability of ethanol feedstock is a crucial plus in times such as these.

POCKET RAVIKANTH



MADAN SABNAVIS

The current oil crisis is the fourth in the last four years. The first episode took place when Russia invaded Ukraine which saw crude price moving from around \$84/barrel in February 2022 to \$117 in March and remaining in a higher range till September, when it moderated to \$90/barrel before reverting to around \$80/barrel in December. Therefore, the higher prices lasted for almost nine months. In this episode, Russia was a major supplier of oil (third largest with share of 10-12 per cent). With a ban being imposed on imports by the western community, supplies were disrupted. The second was the Israel-Palestine conflict in October 2023 but its price impact lasted for just about a month. This is because no oil producing country was involved in this conflict. The third was a short lived war where the US and Israel attacked Iran in June 2025. Here too, the price impact was limited as Iran is not really a major supplier of oil to the world, with its share in global output at around 4 per cent and sanctions still in place. The present war is different. To begin with, almost all the oil producing countries in West Asia are embroiled in this conflict, impacting production of oil and gas. Further, while Iran has not officially closed the Strait of Hormuz, ships will not sail through this passage, given the risks involved. So, there has been greater disruption to the oil industry with shipping costs also going up for all goods passing this region. Significantly, an early end to the war looks unlikely. Ukraine has managed to hold on for four years now.

Fourth, the behaviour of exporters and importers will also hold a clue. In times of uncertainty, exporters hold back earnings, while importers may rush in to buy dollars, exacerbating the demand-supply situation. Lastly, RBI action in the coming days will be important as intervention in the market can quell speculative forces and bring in stability.

IMPACT ON INDIA India imports around five million barrels a day which works out to around \$180 billion (1.8 billion barrels annually) a year. Hence, if the price remains high for the entire year, for every \$10 dollar increase in the price of oil, the import bill be up by \$18 billion. This can lead to an increase in current account deficit by 0.5 per cent of GDP, which should not be a serious issue for India as the balance is fairly comfortable today in the region of 1-1.5 per cent. Exports, however, would be impacted as petro-products are around \$65-70 billion per annum, of which 15 per cent is headed to these vulnerable regions. The immediate impact has been felt on the currency with the rupee crossing the psychological level of ₹92/\$. It is likely to see increased volatility. This market will witness increased volatility. First, the US dollar will also be volatile



Economy may survive war supply shocks

WAGES OF WAR. The rupee and stock markets will remain volatile, but impact on growth and inflation may remain muted

unless the government decides to pass on the higher price of crude to the consumer, which has rarely happened. When crude prices stayed low, the benefit did not go the consumer but to the OMCs. Higher crude prices may not hence lead to an increase in retail prices in the near future as this can be absorbed by the OMCs. In fact, given the fragile global oil situation over the last four years, it may make sense to transfer all future surpluses to an emergency fund that can be used in times of crisis. Further, OMCs do buy oil based on contracts struck with suppliers where the price formula is worked out in advance. Therefore, the increase seen today in the market may not be the price which is finally paid and would be lower. Also, hedging practices are pursued to cover for price risk to an extent. The government would be monitoring the situation carefully. There are a few

issues that merit attention. The first is whether anything can be done on excise duty or VAT (by States) if prices rise further. Second, the subsidy element is low today on LPG which is not an issue. In fact, the price was increased recently to partly offset the higher cost. But supplies are a concern on which a policy has already been indicated to ensure that essential services are not affected. Third, fertilizer prices need to be watched carefully as they affect the subsidy level as well its availability. The stock market would continue to display yo-yo movements reflecting sentiment on a real time basis and hence will be hard to predict in the short run. This will be the case with global indices, too. Last, the bond market has not been affected much. While forex intervention will draw out liquidity, the RBI has already announced OMOs which will be reassuring for the market. Therefore, the length of the war will hold the clue to the final outcome. The government and RBI are seized of the matter and would take the appropriate steps to mitigate the risks. But markets for sure, will remain volatile.

The writer is Chief Economist, Bank of Baroda. Views expressed are personal

Why the ECA has been invoked for LPG supply

The war in Middle East has disrupted gas supplies. The government move is expected to ensure cooking gas for households

bl.explainer

Ramasamy Jayaprakash

The Union government invoked the Essential Commodities Act (ECA), 1955, to deal with supply disruption of natural gas due to the war in West Asia. The government has invoked its emergency powers enshrined under the Act to secure cooking gas to crores of households.

What is the Essential Commodities Act? When is it invoked and how does it help? The Essential Commodities Act (ECA) of 1955 grants the Union government the power to “regulate or prohibit the production, supply, distribution, trade, and commerce of commodities” that are declared as ‘essential’ under the Act. This includes commodities such as food, fertilizers, drugs, and petroleum products. It can be modified by the Centre to add items to the list if need arises. It is typically invoked during crisis to prevent hoarding, black marketing, price gouging and artificial shortages. With the ECA, the government can dictate production, storage, priority allocation and distribution, and fix price caps. The Act serves as a tool for the government to ensure that ordinary citizens are not cut off from basic necessities in times of crisis.



COOKING GAS. Securing supply ANI

Why did the government invoke ECA to secure LPG supplies? India imports more than 60 per cent of its total LPG requirements, with almost 90 per cent of these imports coming from the Persian Gulf through the Strait of Hormuz. The ongoing US-Israel-Iran war has effectively halted vessel movements through this critical maritime chokepoint. With only 25-30 days of LPG inventory available domestically, there is a threat of acute shortage of LPG cylinders in India. As there is little clarity on when this war will end, the government has invoked the ECA to help consumers deal with the crisis. **What are the orders given by the government to secure LPG supplies?** The orders from the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas under the

ECA and the new Natural Gas (Supply Regulation) Order, 2026 gives the following directives: All public and private refineries must divert propane, butane and other C3/C4 streams exclusively for LPG production. The entire additional LPG must be supplied only to the three public-sector oil marketing companies — IndianOil, BPCL and HPCL — for sale to domestic (household) consumers. No diversion for making petrochemicals allowed. A 25-day inter-booking period has been introduced for domestic consumers ordering cylinder refills to prevent hoarding. **What is the impact of the war in India? What is the shortfall likely to be?** With the choking at the Strait of Hormuz, India has been forced to scout for spot cargoes from distant sources such as the US, Norway and Algeria which might add to the cost. While there is no official announcements on the scale of potential shortfall, there are reports of commercial supplies being under severe pressure in cities such as Mumbai, Bengaluru, Chennai and Pune. While roughly 25-30 days’ stock provides a thin buffer, a longer conflict in West Asia could create considerable shortfall if supply from alternate sources

are not scaled up fast enough. **Which sectors are likely to be hit the most by the LPG supply disruption?** The hardest hit are the hotels, restaurants, eateries, bakeries and food courts — many of which have already reported supply halts or cut down of the menu. There is also a fear of temporary shutdowns of hotels and restaurants. Other services such as gas crematoriums, laundry & ironing using gas are also reporting shortages. **How will the pooled gas pricing under the order work?** The uncertainties and the shortages could lead to price surge of LPG, affecting domestic consumers the most. To cushion the financial shock, the government has introduced a ‘pooled pricing’ mechanism. GAIL (India) Ltd has been tasked with coordinating the reallocation of gas from lower-priority users to the top-priority sectors (domestic PNG, CNG, LPG plants and pipeline operations). The Petroleum Planning & Analysis Cell (PPAC) will periodically calculate and notify a single ‘pooled price’ that averages the cost of diverted gas. The entities receiving the gas must give a legal undertaking to accept the pooled price, overriding prior contracts and pricing, to share the burden fairly.

✉ **LETTERS TO EDITOR** Send your letters by email to bleditor@thehindu.co.in or by post to ‘Letters to the Editor’, The Hindu Business Line, Kasturi Buildings, 859-860, Anna Salai, Chennai 600002.

Social media concerns Apropos the Editorial ‘Safety net’ (March 11), Karnataka and Andhra Pradesh’s move to regulate social media access for minors is a timely and prudent response to the growing concerns surrounding the digital lives of young users. Increasing incidents of screen addiction, cyberbullying, exposure to harmful content and psychological stress among adolescents underline the urgency for regulatory safeguards. However, the true effectiveness of such measures will depend on the

rigour of their implementation, particularly in ensuring credible age verification, platform accountability and parental awareness. A coordinated national policy spearheaded by the Centre, and adopted by all States, would ensure consistency, stronger oversight and more meaningful protection for minors. **N Sadhasiva Reddy** Bengaluru

Apropos ‘Safety Net’ (March 11), the Editorial makes a convincing case that restricting access alone will not solve the problem. Platforms are designed to be compulsive, and until that architecture changes, age-based bans will remain easy to circumvent. Karnataka and Andhra Pradesh are right to push for regulation, but State-level rules will always have limited reach. What India needs is a central framework that goes beyond access control. Mandatory default settings that disable autoplay and algorithmic feeds for minors, transparent reporting requirements for platforms, and genuine liability for harm caused to young users would create real accountability. **A Myilsami** Coimbatore

Focus on banking This is with reference to the report ‘PSBs made over ₹28000 cr in 5 years by selling 3rd party financial products’ (March 11). Bankers’ duties are to increase primarily their CASA deposits and utilise these funds of less interest for lending to other sectors with relatively better interest rates and meet the statutory requirements. The banks should not get lured into hawking other financial products for increasing their incomes/commissions. At the same time the customers should also realise that some schemes such as the life insurance are important for them as are housing loans which are of long tenure. Another important issue is the ‘mis-selling’ of some products, which the Finance Minister has rightly flagged, so the bankers have to be more cautious. **Katuru Durga Prasad Rao** Hyderabad



Energy policy success

Deft diplomacy, strategic reserves can avert crisis

Tuhin A Sinha
Sumit Kaushik

The temporary disruption in LPG supplies in parts of India is a reminder of how deeply interconnected the global energy system has become. The closure of the Strait of Hormuz amid escalating tensions in West Asia has triggered shocks across global energy logistics.

The government responded quickly by invoking the Essential Services Maintenance Act to ensure supply chains continue functioning smoothly. Officials have clarified that the disruption is logistical rather than structural and is expected to stabilise soon as alternative supply routes and inventories are activated.

Moments like these test not only the resilience of energy systems but also the maturity of political discourse. The Strait of Hormuz is among the world's most critical energy choke-points. When it is disrupted, the global supply chain inevitably feels the impact. In such extraordinary geopolitical circumstances, responsible politics requires calm assessment rather than alarmism.

A CRITICAL PILLAR

Energy security is a critical pillar of national security for a country that imports nearly 85 per cent of its crude oil requirements. Global oil market disruptions can directly affect inflation, trade balances and economic stability. Recognising this vulnerability, the government has spent the past decade strengthening India's energy resilience through diversification, infrastructure investment and diplomatic engagement.

One key factor behind this resilience is diversification of suppliers. Over the last decade, India has expanded the number of countries from which it imports crude oil. By 2025, the number of supplier nations had increased from 27 to 40. This ensures that no single geopolitical crisis can cripple India's supply chain.

India also maintains significant energy buffers. The country currently holds between six and eight weeks of crude and fuel inventory.

Commercial refiners maintain roughly 25 days of stock while strategic petroleum reserves provide additional coverage. Combined, these reserves allow India to withstand supply disruptions for nearly 70 days.

Strategic petroleum reserves have been particularly important. Underground storage facilities at



ENERGY. A critical pillar of national securityGETTY IMAGES

Visakhapatnam, Mangaluru and Padur provide about 5.3 million tonnes of crude storage capacity. In addition, India maintains substantial onshore crude storage.

Another pillar of stability has been India's pragmatic energy sourcing strategy. Following changes in global markets, India significantly increased imports of discounted Russian crude. By 2025, Russia accounted for roughly 35 per cent of India's oil imports, helping stabilise supplies and shield domestic markets from global price volatility.

During the current crisis, the government has also reviewed contingency options including supply diversification and maritime security.

State run refiners such as Indian Oil, Bharat Petroleum and Hindustan Petroleum have explored alternative supplies from the US, West Africa and Latin America. While these shipments involve longer transit times than Gulf routes, India's diversified supplier network ensures viable alternatives remain available.

Energy security depends not only on infrastructure but also on diplomacy.

India has remained engaged with key regional actors including Israel, Iran, Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates. Such diplomatic balance is crucial in a region that remains central to global energy markets. It is also important because nearly nine million Indians live in West Asia.

The country is projected to be one of the largest drivers of global oil demand growth in the coming years. To support this growth, India has expanded refining capacity and upgraded energy infrastructure.

Energy security is constructed gradually through sustained policy planning, infrastructure investment and diplomatic engagement.

Sinha is National Spokesperson, BJP; Kaushik is a social impact and public policy consultant



RAJASEKHAR VK

The Supreme Court's ruling that telecom spectrum cannot form part of the insolvency estate has been widely reported as a telecom decision. It is considerably more than that. It is a boundary marker in India's insolvency jurisprudence, with implications well beyond mobile networks.

At its core, the Court's reasoning is constitutionally straightforward. Spectrum is a scarce natural resource, owned by the people of India and held in trust by the State. This understanding reflects the constitutional conception of material resources of the community under Article 39(b), which places their control in the service of the common good. The right granted to a telecom operator is not proprietary ownership, but a limited and revocable privilege. Consequently, proceedings under the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code cannot restructure the ownership or control of spectrum.

That formulation is constitutionally elegant. It is also structurally significant, with complex consequences.

For nearly a decade, the IBC has been understood as a dominant economic statute. Its *non obstante* clause, emphasis on creditor primacy and commercial wisdom, and "clean slate" philosophy created the expectation that once insolvency commenced, resolution would be governed by the Code across sectors. Spectrum now stands outside that assumption, marking the first emphatic articulation of a constitutional boundary to that ambition.

The deeper question is this: if insolvency cannot operate upon spectrum because it is a material resource of the community, what of other state-controlled resources?

Telecom is not unique in this architecture. Modern regulated industries are built on entitlements layered upon sovereign ownership.

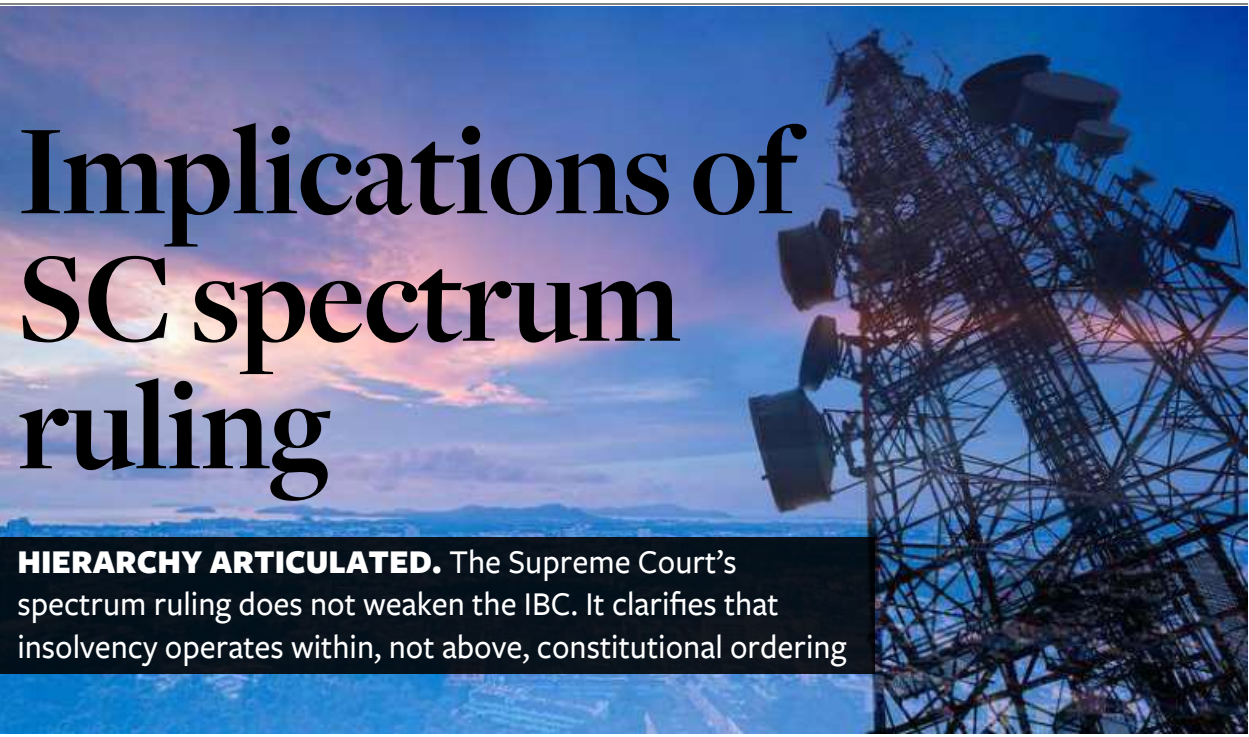
Coal is allocated under statutory auction frameworks. Oil and natural gas exploration rights arise from sovereign grants and production sharing contracts. Electricity generation depends on licences and tariff regulation. Mining leases, airport slots, port concessions, sports broadcasting signals and inland waterways each exist within a comprehensive statutory regime in which the state retains underlying ownership and regulatory control.

The Court's reasoning places constitutional resource governance above insolvency prerogatives. That hierarchy may be theoretically sound. But it reshapes the financial expectations that have grown around regulated industries.

THE PARTICIPATION PARADOX

One under-explored aspect of the spectrum dispute is the state's dual posture: participant within insolvency, yet constitutional arbiter outside it. The Department of Telecommunications filed claims and engaged within the IBC framework.

Yet the judgment makes clear that the transfer or restructuring of spectrum



Implications of SC spectrum ruling

HIERARCHY ARTICULATED. The Supreme Court's spectrum ruling does not weaken the IBC. It clarifies that insolvency operates within, not above, constitutional ordering

cannot be determined by the commercial collective alone.

This creates a dissonance, because insolvency is designed as a creditor-driven process. Committees of Creditors evaluate viability, approve plans and exercise commercial wisdom. But in sectors anchored in sovereign allocation of resources, commercial consensus is no longer decisive; regulatory and constitutional considerations sit above it.

The result? A structural asymmetry. The government may appear in insolvency as a claimant for dues, yet stand outside it as constitutional trustee of the resource. That dual capacity is inherent in regulated industries. The ruling makes clear that the sovereign capacity prevails.

For lenders and resolution applicants, participation in the insolvency process does not exhaust regulatory authority. Resolution cannot be assumed to bind the state as trustee of a natural resource.

THE PHANTOM ASSET DILEMMA

The practical consequences for resolution professionals are significant.

Under the IBC, the resolution professional must preserve the corporate debtor as a going concern and invite plans based on the value of its business. In telecom, the business is inseparable from spectrum usage rights. Those rights appear on the balance sheet as intangible assets and underpin enterprise value.

The judgment does not deny the commercial value of those rights. But it clarifies that accounting recognition does not convert a privilege into an insolvency asset. Spectrum remains outside the estate. This produces an operational dilemma.

Insolvency law does not seek to transfer the underlying resource. It restructures the corporate entity that holds the licence. In theory, a change in

The apex court ruling reminds markets that in sectors anchored in sovereign allocation of scarce resources, constitutional control stands above commercial restructuring

control of a licensee, subject to regulatory approval, need not threaten sovereign ownership. The going concern objective therefore becomes regulator-dependent in a deeper way than in ordinary manufacturing or services sectors, with the regulator and the sovereign statutory framework setting the outer perimeter. Insolvency does not compel, restructure or redraw the underlying entitlement.

The Code assumes that the business can travel through resolution. The judgment reminds markets that where the business rests on a sovereign grant, that travel is conditional.

NOT AN ABSOLUTE PROHIBITION

It is important not to overstate the reach of the ruling. The Court did not declare a change in control of a telecom company impossible. It held that insolvency cannot guide restructuring of ownership or control of spectrum. In other words, the IBC cannot compel or override the telecom regulatory regime, or any statutory regime governing comprehensive public resources.

This leaves open a narrower path. A resolution plan may still propose a change in control. The Department of Telecommunications may consider that proposal under its existing statutory framework, as it would in a merger or acquisition outside insolvency. Resolution applicants must not only negotiate with creditors; they must operate within a constitutional boundary that places sovereign control first.

The distinction is important, as the decisional centre of gravity now shifts from the commercial collective to the sectoral regulator. Insolvency becomes one process among others, not the master framework.

For markets, this means resolution in resource-linked sectors will increasingly resemble coordinated negotiation between creditors and regulators rather than a purely creditor-driven restructuring.

REPRICING REGULATED RISK

The financial implications are immediate. If spectrum usage rights cannot be treated as insolvency assets capable of transfer or monetisation, lenders must reassess how they evaluate similar entitlements. The same inquiry arises wherever enterprise value

depends substantially on State-conferred licences or concessions.

Are banks financing proprietary assets, or access subject to pervasive regulatory control and constitutional doctrine?

The answer affects leverage, covenant structures, risk pricing and recovery modelling. In resource-intensive sectors, insolvency is no longer merely a balance-sheet exercise. It is embedded in public law. Lenders must treat it as a conditional privilege, not collateral in the conventional sense.

LEGISLATIVE CLARITY

The judgment exposes a broader structural issue. The IBC was drafted with distressed industrial and service enterprises in mind. It assumes that "assets" can be owned, transferred and realised. It does not draw a sharp distinction between proprietary assets and regulatory entitlements.

Companies in mining, energy, infrastructure and broadcasting will continue to enter insolvency when they default. The question is how far the insolvency framework can go in reorganising the entitlements on which those companies depend.

The judiciary has clarified the constitutional position: insolvency cannot rewrite sovereign control over public resources. The question is: how should insolvency and sectoral regulators interact in practice? Should there be defined timelines for regulatory decisions during CIRP? Should statutory frameworks expressly address transfer of licensed businesses in insolvency? These are questions for Parliament and policymakers.

The spectrum ruling does not weaken the IBC. It clarifies that insolvency operates within, not above, constitutional ordering. In its early years, the Code shifted power from promoters to creditors. In this judgment, the Court recalibrates the equation once more, reminding markets that in sectors anchored in sovereign allocation of scarce resources, constitutional control stands above commercial restructuring.

Telecom is the first arena in which this hierarchy has been tested and articulated so clearly.

The writer is a lawyer and former Judicial Member of the National Company Law Tribunal

thehindubusinessline.

TWENTY YEARS AGO TODAY.

March 12, 2006

IIMB grad creates history

Finally it was \$193,000. Mr Gaurav Aggarwal, of the graduating batch of the Indian Institute of Management, Bangalore, has created history with his offer letter from Barclays Capital, London. He's now the highest-ever-paid graduate across all IIMs. On Friday, the Day Zero of placements at the IIMB, Barclays Capital, London, offered Mr Aggarwal an international posting and a salary close to ₹86 lakh a year.

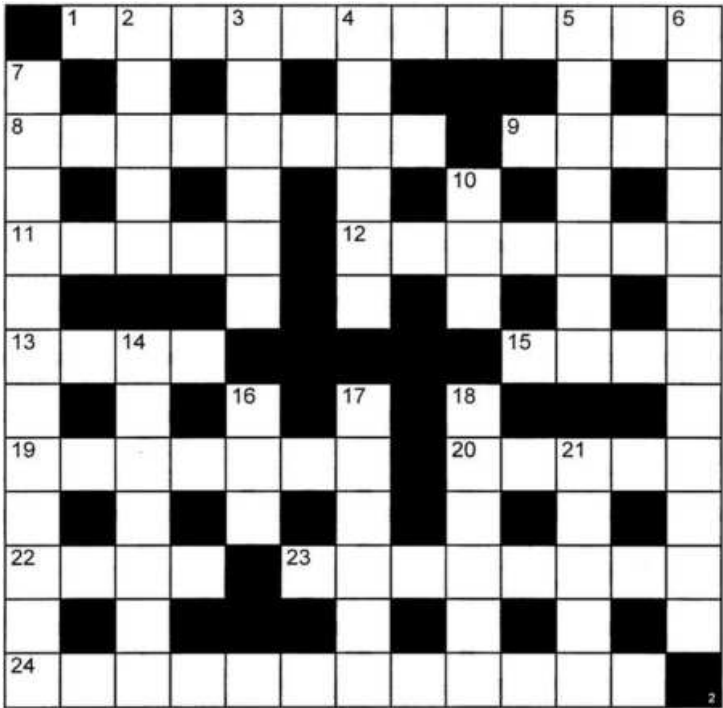
States against plan to list LPG in 'declared goods'

State Finance Ministers, under the aegis of the VAT Panel, are demanding full Central compensation of the revenue loss that would be suffered by the States on account of the Budget proposal to include LPG in the list of 'declared goods' under the CST Act. By this inclusion, the States cannot levy a VAT/sales tax rate of over 4 per cent on this product.

Nokia suppliers to set up units near Chennai

Two of Nokia's suppliers have decided to set up plants at Sriperumbudur, about 50 km west of Chennai. The two suppliers — Aspocom Group Oyj and Perlos Corporation — will together invest \$82 million (about ₹365 crore).

BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2635



EASY

ACROSS

- More than a little, of importance (12)
- Apostate, turncoat (8)
- Apartment (4)
- Vehemence, violence (5)
- Cone-bearing tree (7)
- Flank (4)
- Defendant's answer to charge (4)
- Spanish princess (7)
- ____'s rod: mullein (5)
- Require (4)
- Strong attachment; consecration (8)
- Paris students' area (5,7)

DOWN

- Proprietor (5)
- Clay box for packing pottery for baking (6)
- Infer from premises (6)
- Malignant (look) (7)
- Acting as host (12)
- Non-amateur (12)
- Entity as opposed to attribute (3)
- Turn aside, cause to deviate (7)
- Whatever amount (3)
- Gift, present (Fr) (6)
- To smack, have a flavour (6)
- Elevate (5)

NOT SO EASY

ACROSS

- Deem it capable of providing quite a lot (12)
- Turncoat might need to change gear (8)
- Sort of race for accommodation (4)
- Compulsion to start criticising in warning from golfer (5)
- Sort of tree nice for planting out (7)
- It may be the right pretentious air (4)
- Scottish lawsuit would be sure to provide gratification (4)
- Princess in Madrid discovered tan if an adjustment was made (7)
- Jewish high-priest whose rod may be found in bed (5)
- Not to have been born of woman, a daughter (4)
- Piety voted out as having one on (8)
- Around the Sorbonne it's a dead language - mercy! (5,7)

DOWN

- Proprietor produced nothing new at end of a year (5)
- Clay box potter uses, for example, with rags (6)
- Infer that Mussolini was half-dead to begin with (6)
- So malignant, it could be a full version of it (7)
- Being a host may prove amusing (12)
- Paid performer for spies, loan being arranged (12)
- An entity creating small spaces in print (3)
- In the wrong cleft, Ted found he could turn it aside (7)
- Whatever the number, a lot lose their head (3)
- A gift the French have, putting the boulder on water there (6)
- Enjoy taste of what's lemony around a vanilla topping (6)
- More money is available in a different era (5)

SOLUTION: BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2634

ACROSS 1. Addict 8. Pearl 9. Suspect 11. Tendency 12. Beard 15. Lava 16. Row 17. Axle 19. Poppy 21. Standard 24. Yearned 25. Metal 26. Larder

DOWN 2. Deuce 3. Imperial 4. Tact 5. Spade 6. Barn 7. Play 10. Temporary 12. Bill 13. Labourer 14. Demy 18. Oddly 20. Piece 21. Same 22. Acts 23. Deal

A meaningful upgrade that ticks key boxes

NOTHING 4A. A stylish smartphone with an edgy design complemented by a clutter-free user experience



EXCEEDING EXPECTATIONS. Nothing has raised the bar with the triple rear cam: the 50MP Samsung JN5 periscope lens offers 3.5x optical zoom and 7x in-sensor zoom. ASHWIN RAJAGOPALAN

Ashwin Rajagopalan

It's 2026, we're seeing a marked increase in smartphone prices as the industry grapples with a RAM shortage and rising input costs. Nothing's 'a Series' devices have typically battled in the sub ₹30,000 price band. The brand's newest Nothing 4a has just dropped with a starting price of ₹31,999. That brings us to the obvious question, does this device deliver a user experience that justifies the price hike over last year's Nothing 3a? The short answer is yes.

DESIGN
Nothing has leaned heavily on design to break the clutter, the Nothing 4a is a case in point. It's one of the best looking smart-

phones you can buy right now with a range of colours, including a standout Pink colourway. The 4a sticks with Nothing's trademark industrial and transparent design. Nothing has also improved the ergonomics; the device feels better in your hand than the 3a. The camera bar has moved slightly and looks even more refined than its predecessor.

We also liked the redesigned Glyph Bar that opts for an uncomplicated layout. You get six vertical LED squares that are made up of 63 mini-LEDs. Nothing offers a host of customisations for its popular Glyph interface, including alterations to the brightness of the LED squares. Nothing tells us that the 4a is submersible in up to 25 cm of water for up to 20 minutes. The phone is IP64 certified for dust and water resistance but there are smartphones in this price band that offer better

ingress protection. Nothing has moved the Essential Key (that allows you to capture screenshots that the phone can organise with its AI solution) to the left side. This is a good 'move' given that we've often accidentally ended up pressing this button (that was previously on the right side along with the volume rocker) while looking for the power button.

DISPLAY
This is one area where Nothing has made a significant change over the Nothing 3a. The 4a sports a 6.78-inch LTPS flexible AMOLED display (1224 x 2720 pixels/440 PPI). This 1.5K display is a marked improvement over the Full HD display from last year. It peaks at 4500 nits with an outdoor brightness of 1600 nits. Colours are punchy and the display offers excellent visibility even under direct sunlight. While the dis-

play supports HDR support for YouTube, it still doesn't offer this option for Netflix yet. I watched an episode from the second season of *Kohrra* and the lack of HDR support didn't really impact the viewing experience that was complemented by the dual stereo speakers.

PERFORMANCE
Nothing hasn't built its sales pitch around chipset performance or your need for speed. The 4a is propelled by a Qualcomm Snapdragon 7s Gen 4 chipset. The device comes in three storage options — 8 GB/128 GB, 8 GB/256 GB and the top-end 12 GB/256 GB version that we tested.

The device aced everyday tasks and notched a respectable score of 3,376 in our Geekbench (multi-core) test. It's not the fastest in a segment that also includes options such as the OnePlus Nord 5

but it has all the firepower most users need. The device runs on Nothing OS 4.1 powered by Android 16. It's one of our favourite custom versions of Android with a minimalist interface that complements the phone's industrial design. But there are brands that offer more customisable options with their versions of Android. We would also have liked to see more than three years of Android OS updates.

Battery life gets a boost with a 5,400 mAh battery that lasted a whole day in our tests with moderate to heavy usage. The device offers 50 W wired charging (there's no charging brick in the box) that powers the device to 100 per cent in just over an hour.

CAMERA
Nothing has raised the bar with the triple rear cam on the 4a. The highlight is the 50 MP Samsung



Camera 3.5x zoom



Camera 10x zoom



Lowlight image shot



Macro images are quite impressive

JN5 periscope lens that offers 3.5x optical zoom and 7x in-sensor zoom. It's one of the only mobile shooters at this price point to offer a 70x ultra zoom option.

We put this zoom lens through the scanner; the results were quite impressive up to 10x zoom. The camera set up also includes a 50MP (f/1.88) primary lens and an 8MP (f/2.2) ultra-wide lens. The Nothing 4a delivers a solid camera performance in optimal light. Portraits are sharp with good edge detection and the 4a shoots better lowlight images compared to the 3a. However, lowlight images with the ultra-wide lens were not in the same league. This is not unusual at this price point. There's also a 32 MP selfie shooter in the mix.

VERDICT
The Nothing 4a comes with quite

a few thoughtful upgrades over the 3a. It sticks with the same appeal that has worked with Nothing's legion of fans that prioritises user experience and a unique approach to smartphone design.

The device comes with enhancements that cover most bases, including an improved display and a versatile rear shooter, making it one of the best buys in the ₹30,000-₹40,000 price segment right now.

● SNAPSHOT

Price: ₹31,999 onwards
Pros: Unique design and user interface, zoom capabilities, vibrant display
Cons: Low light performance on ultra-wide mode, only three years of OS updates.

TECH DIGEST.

Team Technophile

ChatGPT to provide more visuals for science and maths

Each week, 140 million people turn to ChatGPT to understand math and science concepts alone. To make learning these concepts even more



interactive, ChatGPT will guide learners by showing how formulas, variables and relationships behave in real time. When someone asks ChatGPT about one of the core

topics, it can explain and present it through an interactive visual module. Users can manipulate variables, formulas to see how those changes affect graphs and outcomes — turning abstract equations into something they can experiment with directly. The list of math and science topics include binomial square, Charles' law, circle area, cone surface area, Pythagorean theorem and more. Over time, OpenAI plans to expand interactive learning with additional subjects. This will be available globally across all plans.

ASUS launches V501 Desktop and AiO V400 series

ASUS India recently announced the launch of the ASUS V501 Desktop series and the ASUS AiO V400 series, expanding its consumer PC portfolio



suited for both home and work environments. The ASUS V501 Desktops, including the V501MV Mini Tower and V501SV Small Form Factor, is designed for SOHOs, studios

and small organisations for day-to-day computing. Alongside this, ASUS has introduced the AiO V400 series, which includes the V440 and V470, built to support modern households with a streamlined all-in-one design for everyday multitasking, learning and entertainment.

The line-up starts at ₹42,990 for the ASUS V501 Desktop series, ₹67,990 for the AiO V440 and ₹71,990 for the AiO V470, with the ASUS V501SV and AiO V470 available from March 5. These ranges will be available across ASUS exclusive stores, ASUS e-shop, Amazon, Flipkart, Croma and authorised ASUS retail partners.

Sonos introduces Sonos Play and Era 100 SL

Sonos has introduced Sonos Play and Sonos Era 100TM SL, two Sonos speaker systems designed to deliver room-filling sound. Sonos Play is designed



as a versatile speaker, offering rich stereo sound with both Wi-Fi and Bluetooth connectivity, along with a portable design, 24-hour battery life and IP67 water resistance. The Era 100 SL is a

simplified, mic-free speaker that provides an accessible entry point into the Sonos ecosystem. Both speakers are built to work seamlessly with the broader Sonos system, allowing users to expand their listening experience across rooms over time without replacing existing devices. General availability for Sonos Play and Sonos Era 100 SL in India will be announced soon.

Chrome expands AI experiences to India, NZ and Canada

As part of its latest update, Google is bringing many of Chrome's latest AI features, including Gemini, to India, New Zealand and Canada.



Support for more than 50 additional languages, including Hindi, Bengali, Gujarati, Kannada, Malayalam, Marathi, Telugu and Tamil are also part of this.

With Gemini in Chrome, users can multi-task with ease and instantly get help with whatever one is working on, without ever having to switch tabs. Just click the icon in the top right corner of your current tab and start chatting with your personalised browsing assistant.

With built-in Google integrations, users can schedule meetings on the Calendar, see location details from Maps and ask questions about YouTube videos. Nano Banana 2 also comes directly built into Chrome, allowing users to transform images on the go. Gemini in Chrome allows users to consolidate information from multiple open tabs into a single view. The tool can extract and organise data from different websites like travel itineraries or product specifications to create comparison tables or summaries within the browser.

From entry-level to high-end: Apple's March line-up for the diverse market

REFINED ECOSYSTEM. Explore the highlights of the latest powerhouse releases

Siddharth Mathew Cherian

The first week of March proved to be a milestone for Apple fans as the tech giant signalled a serious commitment to India and other developing markets. In a rapid three-day blitz (March 2-4), Apple unveiled everything from a mid-range smartphone and a budget MacBook to an M4-powered iPad Air and the high-end M5 Pro and Max MacBook Pros as well as Studio Display XDR. While opinions vary on the target audience for such a diverse line-up, we take a look at the new products.

IPHONE 17E

The iPhone 17e is the successor to Apple's much touted replacement to its SE lineup — the 16e. The iPhone 17e has the latest-generation A19 processor and features the C1X cellular modem chip designed by Apple. The A19 chip is the same processor that was used in the regular iPhone 17 from last year. It also starts with 256 gigabytes of storage, double last year's entry-level offering of 128 GB. The iPhone 17e starts at ₹64,900 for 256 GB storage.

MACBOOK NEO

With the MacBook Neo, Apple enters the entry-level computing space previously dominated by Chromebooks. By pairing a mobile-class chip with a full desktop OS, the Neo offers a streamlined, high-end experience for the education and home-use sectors.

The Neo features a 13-inch liquid retina display and is powered by the A18 Pro chip. Built of aluminium, the Neo is available in four colours: Blush, indigo, silver and citrus, and weighs 1.23 kg. Battery life is rated at up to 16 hours on a single charge. Connectivity includes two USB-C ports, a 3.5 mm headphone jack, Wi-Fi 6E,



Apple iPhone 17e



Apple MacBook Neo



Apple iPad Air M4



Apple MacBook M5 Pro/M5 Max



MacBook Air

and Bluetooth 6. The laptop runs macOS Tahoe, which is a surprise, considering this is a mobile processor. It also supports Apple Intelligence features and integration with iPhone through Continuity features such as Handoff, Universal Clipboard and iPhone Mirroring.

IPAD AIR

The iPad Air features the M4 chip. It is available in two sizes (11-inch and 13-inch) and four finishes (Space Grey, Blue, Purple and Starlight). Apple claims the M4-based iPad Air is up to 30 per cent faster than the M3 version and up to 2.3 times faster than the M1 model. The Air uses Apple's N1 and C1X connectivity chips, adding support for Wi-Fi 7 and improved cellular connectivity. The iPad Air with M4 comes at ₹64,900 for the 11-inch model and ₹84,900 for the 13-inch model.

M5 PRO, M5 MAX

The MacBook Pro gets new M5 Pro and M5 Max processors, which Apple claims provides 5.4x faster video effects, renders in Blackmagic Davinci Resolve and 1.6x faster gaming performance with ray tracing in games such as Cyberpunk 2077: Ultimate Edition as compared to the M4. While nothing much has changed design wise in the M5 Pro and Max MacBook Pro, the base storage has been increased to 1 TB as opposed to the 512 GB base level storage in the M4. The 14-inch MacBook Pro with M5 Pro starts at ₹2,49,900 and the 16-inch MacBook Pro with M5 Pro starts at ₹2,99,900 with base 1 TB storage.

MACBOOK AIR M5

Apple updated the MacBook Air with M5 processor and the Air comes in a thin, light and durable aluminium design with liquid retina display, 12 MP

Centre Stage camera, up to 18 hours of battery life, an immersive sound system with Spatial Audio and two Thunderbolt 4 ports. Prices start at ₹1,19,900 for the 13-inch and ₹1,44,900 for the 15-inch MacBook Air.

The interesting part is that like the Pros, the Air's base storage has been increased from 256 to 512 GB along with a slight price increase. However, at a time when storage and RAM prices are growing, the availability of a bigger storage base variant, albeit at a slightly higher price than the previous versions, is to be expected.

Apple has laid out its most diverse roadmap for India and global markets to date, simultaneously targeting value-conscious students and high-end professionals. As these devices hit the shelves on March 11, all eyes are on the market response across India and Asia to gauge the success of this multi-tier strategy.

AIF-backed IPOs must have fair price: SEBI

LONG-TERM GOAL. Managers should help prepare investee companies for life as listed entities with stronger governance practices

Akshata Gorde
Mumbai

Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) Chairman Tuhin Kanta Pandey urged alternative investment funds (AIFs) to adopt stricter valuation practices as more portfolio companies prepare to tap public markets, warning that weak pricing frameworks could undermine investor confidence.

“AIFs often invest in early-stage and illiquid assets. In such cases, credibility begins with valuation,” Pandey said at the IVCA Conclave on Wednesday. “Weak or opaque valuations erode confidence. When investee companies move toward public markets, valuation concerns can distort price discovery

and weaken trust. Therefore, fair valuation matters.”

His remarks come as private equity and venture capital-backed companies increasingly look to exit through initial public offerings. According to industry estimates, dozens of such companies are expected to approach public markets in the coming quarters.

Pandey also said AIF managers must help prepare investee companies for life as listed entities by embedding stronger governance practices early.

As businesses move to public ownership, they must be ready for stronger governance standards, including independent boards, robust related party safeguards and audit discipline. AIFs that embed these practices early



ON VALUATION. Tuhin Kanta Pandey, Chairperson, SEBI, at the Indian Venture and Alternate Capital Association conclave REUTERS

help create stronger, market-ready companies, he said.

GROWING INDUSTRY
India's AIF industry has expanded rapidly in recent years. The country now has over 1,700 registered AIFs, with total commitments of about ₹15.74 trillion and investments of ₹6.45 trillion as of December 2025, reflecting

a compound annual growth rate of nearly 30 per cent over the past five years.

Pandey said the sector plays a key role in channeling long-term capital into areas where traditional financing may be limited.

However, he cautioned that the industry must ensure that growth is accompanied by stronger stand-

ards. “On market development, we expect robust risk management, disciplined valuation practices, prudent investment behaviour, ethical portfolio management and increasing integration of ESG considerations where relevant. In short, growth must be accompanied by standards, that is non-negotiable,” he said.

FASTER LAUNCHES
At the same time, SEBI is looking to ease certain processes to improve efficiency in the AIF ecosystem.

Pandey said the regulator is exploring a “lodge and launch” model for certain AIF schemes, under which reliance could be placed on due diligence certificates issued by merchant bankers.

For certain AIF schemes, reliance can be placed on due diligence certificates from merchant bankers. “This framework can improve ease of doing business, accelerate fund launches and support faster mobilisation of private capital,” he said. For schemes meant only for accredited investors, AIF managers would remain responsible for disclosure and due diligence.

The number of accredited investors has also increased sharply — from 649 in May 2025 to 2,181 as of February 2026.

Going ahead, the regulator is also looking to streamline accreditation through digital public infrastructure and reduce the cost of certification. Pandey also called on AIFs to deploy more capital into innovation-led sectors.

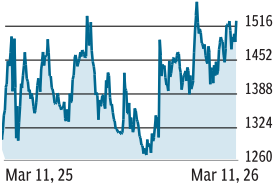
TODAY'S PICK.

Ipca Laboratories (₹1,532.20): BUY

Gurumurthy K
BL Research Bureau

Ipca Laboratories

Return 19% ₹ 1532 1580



The short-term outlook is bullish for Ipca Laboratories. The stock has been going gradually higher over the past month. The recent price action indicates that the stock is getting good buyers around ₹1,450.

Below this, ₹1,410 will be the next support. Moving average crossovers on the daily chart also strengthen the bullish case.

It indicates that the downside could be limited from here, Ipca Laboratories' share price can rise to ₹1,640 in the coming weeks.

Traders can buy Ipca Laboratories shares now at ₹1,532. Accumulate on dips at ₹1,510. Keep the stop-loss at ₹1,460.

Trail the stop-loss up to ₹1,555 as soon as the stock goes up to ₹1,575. Revise the

stop-loss higher to ₹1,580 and ₹1,610 when the price touches ₹1,605 and ₹1,620 respectively. Exit the long positions at ₹1,640.

The bullish view will go wrong if the stock declines below ₹1,410.

If that happens, then there is a danger of the price tumbling to ₹1,300-₹1,260 thereafter. But such a fall looks less likely at the moment.

Note: The recommendations are based on technical analysis. There is a risk of loss in trading.

Sedemac ends 7% higher at ₹1,451.10 on day 1 of listing

Madhu Balaji
Bengaluru

Sedemac Mechatronics made a strong market debut on Wednesday by listing with a 12–13.5 per cent premium over the issue price of ₹1,352, but closed with gains of only over 7 per cent due to overall weak market conditions.

The listing reflected healthy investor appetite for the power-train controls and automotive components manufacturer.

On the National Stock Exchange, the stock debuted at a 13.5 per cent premium at ₹1,535 and later climbed further to hit a high of ₹1,613.50. On the BSE, it opened at ₹1,510, up 12 per cent.

It ended at ₹1,451.10 on the NSE and ₹1,452.10 on the BSE, respectively.

The ₹1,087-crore IPO received an overall subscription of 2.68 times. Demand was led by institutional investors, with the qualified institutional buyers segment subscribing 8.46 times. The portion reserved for non-institutional investors saw a subscription of 77 per cent, while the retail investors category saw a subscription of 20 per cent.

Ahead of the IPO, the company raised ₹326 crore from anchor investors.

The IPO was entirely an offer-for-sale of up to 80,43,300 equity shares by promoters Manish Sharma and Ashwini Amit Dixit, along with other selling shareholders.

The price band for the issue was fixed at ₹1,287 to ₹1,352 per share.

Sedemac Mechatronics manufactures advanced engine and power-train control systems and supplies to leading automotive manufacturers, including TVS Motor Company, Bajaj Auto, Kirloskar Oil Engines, Briggs & Stratton and DEIF India.

Raajmarg Infra InVIT: Suitable for HNIs looking for yields, mild appreciation

Venkatasubramanian K
bl. research bureau

The NHAI-sponsored Raajmarg Infra Investment Trust is coming out with an issue to raise funds.

THE ISSUE

The total issue size, including the contribution of the sponsor NHAI (15 per cent or ₹900 crore), is ₹6,000 crore, offered at a price band of ₹99-100 per unit. It is an entirely fresh issue. The NHAI will receive the concession value from the InvIT via the IPO proceeds for the tolled road projects.

IPO ANALYSIS.

Of the balance ₹5,100 crore, EPFO has committed ₹1,000 crore as a strategic investor, as has SBI Life with ₹260 crore. The remaining ₹3,840 crore would be up for bidding, with institutional investors making up 75 per cent (₹2,880 crore) and non-institutional investors accounting for the balance 25 per cent (₹960 crore).

There is no separate retail investor quota. The offer is open and closes on Friday.

SMOOTH RIDE

Since the trust itself was formed only in December 2025 and the tolling revenue for the purpose of the Raajmarg Infra Investment Trust starts from FY27 and runs up to FY41, there is no prior record available for this issue.

There are five highway stretches that are part of this infrastructure investment trust with seven toll plazas. The total tolling length is about 345.5 km.

Gorhar Barwa Adda (GBA), Chilakuripet-Vijayawada (VC), Chennai Bypass (CB), Chennai-Tada (CT) and Nelamangala-Tumkur (NT) are the five highways that will be tolled with tolling lengths ranging from



Five highway stretches that are part of Raajmarg infra investment trust have seven toll plazas JOTHI RAMALINGAM B

43km to 87 km. Of the total ₹925.5 crore revenue projected for FY27, the split across the highway stretches would be: GBA (16.8 per cent of revenue), VC (24.4 per cent), CB (22.2 per cent), CT (15.9) and NT (20.7 per cent).

The total toll revenues from FY27 to FY41 are expected to grow at 8.1 per cent CAGR – from ₹925.8 crore to ₹2,738.7 crore.

Over this same period, EBITDA is projected to increase 7.6 per cent annually — from ₹876.6 crore in FY27 to ₹2,442.1 crore in FY41. The EBITDA margin would start at almost 95 per cent and taper down to a still healthy 89.2 per cent by FY41.

The compounded annual growth projection for the vehicular traffic over FY27 to FY41 has been kept moderate at 3.5 per cent.

The concession period is fairly long at 15 years and so lends considerable revenue visibility via the toll collections. All the tolls are already functional with a track record, and so are in a fairly steady state of generating revenues.

There are clauses in the concession agreements that prevent the building of competing roads in these stretches and also for compensation when additional tollways disrupt existing arrangements.

Finally and, as a key factor, the toll rates are subject to

upward revision. Toll rates would increase by 3 per cent plus 40 per cent of the WPI (wholesale price index) annually, thus comfortably offering inflation pass-through.

VALUATION

The third-party valuer has given a total figure of around ₹9,299 crore as enterprise value for the projects (tolled stretches) that are part of this offering as of December 31, 2025. This gives an assumed debt position of around ₹3,300 crore for the trust. With this figure, the EV/EBITDA multiple for the issue comes to about 10.6 times based on FY27 EBITDA figures. This is lower than NHIT, which trades at over 18 times and Cube Highways Trust's multiple of 12.3 times. Vertis Infrastructure Trust trades at around 10.2 times.

The dividend yield is the real sweetener in the case of highway InvITs. NHAI's own NHIT and Cube offer over 7 per cent dividend yield, while Vertis gave around 5.6 per cent.

With an EBITDA figure of ₹876.6 crore, it is quite possible for Raajmarg Infrastructure Investment Trust to easily match these dividend yields, as major maintenance capex is scheduled only from FY33 onwards. Initial improvement works in FY27 and FY28 are expected to cost only about ₹66.9 crore.

The issue suits HNIs wanting stable and reasonable returns with modest capital appreciation. They can apply for the IPO with a 3-5-year perspective.

Retail investors with higher disposable surplus can apply for regular cash flows and portfolio diversification. InvITs are mandated to distribute 90 per cent of their net distributable cash flows as dividends to investors.

PGIM India MF allows only SIPs in 3 global funds

Our Bureau

Mumbai

PGIM India Mutual Fund has imposed temporary restrictions on investment in its overseas-focused funds, including Global Equity Opportunities Fund of Fund, Emerging Markets Equity Fund of Fund and PGIM India Global Select Real Estate Securities Fund of Fund.

The fund house will process only existing systematic investment plans in these schemes, and will stop accepting lump sum and new SIP registration.

INVESTMENT CAP

The move follows SEBI's directions to all fund houses not to breach the individual limits assigned to them. The market regulator had restricted MF overseas investments to a total industry limit of \$7 billion, with an additional \$1 billion for overseas ETFs.

The limits, mandated by the RBI, have caused several fund houses to pause new inflows into foreign-focused schemes.

Nifty 50 Movers					
	Close(R)	Pts	PE	Wt(%)	
Sun Pharma	1825.90	3.04	40.00	1.78	
NITFC	379.90	2.70	14.84	1.66	
Jio Financial Services Ltd.	385.20	1.94	94.50	0.72	
Coal India	446.75	1.59	9.25	0.93	
Dr Reddys Lab	1325.50	1.46	20.03	0.74	
ONGC	270.75	1.32	7.57	0.97	
Wipro	202.23	0.81	15.91	0.53	
Hindalco	959.10	0.79	13.41	1.28	
PowerGrid Corp	298.80	0.15	17.90	0.41	
ITC	309.00	-0.11	18.70	0.24	
Tech Mahindra	1334.40	-0.31	28.48	0.78	
Tata Steel	194.74	-0.47	26.65	1.48	
Cipla	1329.50	-0.49	23.69	0.69	
Grasim Ind	2735.60	-0.70	19.66	0.96	
NestleIndia	1235.70	-1.18	72.94	0.81	
Adani Enter	1974.70	-1.25	18.13	0.47	
IntGlobeAvi	4350.70	-1.47	52.38	0.90	
Max Healthcare	1032.20	-1.78	70.75	0.71	
HOFC Life	647.90	-1.93	73.96	0.64	
Adani Ports	1410.80	-2.15	26.01	0.96	
SBI Life	1938.60	-2.47	78.42	0.80	
HCL Tech	1350.30	-2.59	37.14	0.82	
Apollo Hosp	7684.00	-2.69	59.22	0.73	
TataConsumerProduct	1073.40	-3.73	72.18	0.64	
Trent Ltd.	3627.40	-4.28	79.61	0.74	
Eternal Ltd.	223.80	-4.44	934.96	1.48	
Tata Motors PV	335.35	-4.52	45.60	0.64	
Asian Paints	2232.00	-4.80	54.75	0.93	
UltraTech Cement	11462.00	-4.99	44.08	1.25	
Unilever	2161.40	-5.61	50.51	1.76	
Bajaj Auto	9327.50	-6.87	29.32	0.95	
Titan	4140.30	-7.23	77.12	1.57	
Bharat Elec	454.10	-7.27	55.67	1.50	
JSW Steel	1178.80	-7.32	37.12	1.02	
EicherMotors	7353.50	-8.55	37.14	0.92	
Bajaj Finserv	1795.30	-9.09	14.94	0.94	
L&T	3838.80	-9.58	27.83	1.14	
Shriram Finance Ltd.	1031.70	-9.59	21.22	1.33	
Maruti Suzuki	13497.00	-10.65	28.42	1.63	
TCS	2464.90	-10.80	18.59	2.31	
Kotak Bank	1178.80	-13.95	20.27	2.59	
Infosys	1276.30	-14.83	18.48	4.11	
State Bank	1091.10	-19.21	11.64	4.16	
M&M	3168.20	-24.58	21.31	2.60	
Bharti Airtel	1807.00	-26.53	27.81	4.63	
Bajaj Finance	893.65	-26.88	30.35	2.18	
ICICI Bank	1294.60	-27.11	16.35	8.50	
Reliance Ind	1390.20	-27.55	37.14	1.62	
Axis Bank	1258.80	-37.03	14.76	3.31	
HOFC Bank	833.95	-52.01	16.57	11.73	

Pts: Impact on index movement

Nifty Next 50 Movers					
	Close(R)	Pts	PE	Wt(%)	
Tata Power	385.75	22.42	24.61	2.92	
Abb India	6280.00	8.73	78.91	1.49	
Indian Oil Corp	169.63	7.74	6.15	2.71	
Havells	1365.50	5.68	57.76	1.55	
Torrent Pharma	4431.20	1.07	66.01	2.09	
Jindal Steel	1187.00	-0.22	60.06	2.00	
Siemens	3272.20	-0.72	73.50	1.30	
Avenuesuper	3944.80	-0.88	89.62	2.62	
Zydislife Sciences	921.75	-1.01	18.45	1.04	
Adani Power	138.85	-1.07	23.70	2.47	
Jsw Energy	488.00	-1.13	32.76	1.18	
Vedanta	721.55	-2.29	17.03	5.52	
Bajaj Housing Finance	83.74	-2.42	28.16	0.35	
Hindus Zinc	587.60	-3.06	21.04	1.15	
Cg Power & Ind Sol	726.30	-3.91	103.10	2.25	
Ambuja Cements	2942.80	-3.93	88.72	1.17	
Bpcl	325.05	-4.94	5.73	2.84	
Rural Elec	333.05	-5.06	5.09	1.88	
Adanigreenergy	849.65	-6.67	75.41	1.18	
Divis Lab	6352.50	-7.43	68.03	3.64	
Indian Railway Finance Corp	99.25	-7.83	18.51	0.80	
Ambuja Cements	2942.80	-7.87	22.99	1.26	
Shree Cement	23740.00	-8.83	47.69	1.43	
Bosch	31715.00	-9.50	33.93	1.24	
ICIci Lombard Gic	1875.20	-10.24	34.15	2.05	
Mazagon Dock	2436.10	-10.49	40.83	0.84	
Lac	802.40	-12.65	9.57	0.80	
Indian Hotels Co	624.05	-14.10	41.04	2.47	
Bajaj Holdings	10177.00	-14.55	12.64	1.99	
Solar Industries	14515.00	-14.98	86.03	1.60	
Britannia Ind	5921.50	-16.45	59.02	3.15	
Limtintree	4262.70	-16.80	26.75	1.78	
Punjab Natl Bank	115.84	-17.48	7.45	1.80	
Macrotech Developers	88.40	-18.19	26.28	1.12	
Gail India	147.97	-18.78	11.31	1.60	
HindustanAeronautics	4005.10	-19.92	30.11	4.43	
Varun Beverages	431.25	-21.56	47.63	2.66	
Dif	573.20	-21.84	32.04	1.66	
United Spirits	1382.10	-22.15	58.45	1.84	
Adani Energy Solutions	992.00	-22.48	49.99	1.55	
Power Finance	2403.40	-22.64	61.72	1.97	
Power Finance	406.90	-22.93	4.02	2.67	
Info Edge I	956.50	-23.43	36.81	1.68	
Godrej Consumer	1091.40	-24.39	61.31	1.98	
Samvardmotheresoninternatl	121.39	-26.92	35.20	2.43	
Bank Of Baroda	289.30	-28.39	7.62	2.42	
Canara Bank	139.41	-28.93	6.87	2.12	
Hyundai Motor India	2019.90	-34.18	28.35	1.30	
Cholamandalamin&Fin	1557.40	-81.84	27.11	2.97	
Tvs Motor Cmp	360.80	-129.83	56.02	3.81	

Pts: Impact on index movement

^Please refer to the heading 'A. Asset Allocation' under Part 'II. Information about the Scheme' of Scheme Information Document where the concept of Macaulay duration has been explained.

*Distribution of the above IDCW is subject to the availability of distributable surplus and may be lower to the extent of distributable surplus available on the record date. IDCW payable to the unit holder(s) will be lower to the extent of tax deducted at source, at applicable rates.

#or immediately following Business Day if that day is not a Business Day.

Face Value per unit is Rs. 1,000/-.

Pursuant to payment of IDCW, the NAV of the specified options of the aforesaid schemes would fall to the extent of payout and statutory levy, if any.

Unit holders of the aforesaid schemes, whose names appear in the records of the Registrar, KFin Technologies Limited, as at the close of business hours on **Monday, March 16, 2026** or immediately following Business Day (including valid purchase/switch-in application received till 3.00 p.m. on the record date, subject to the entire amount of subscription/ purchase as per the application / switch-in request is available for utilization by the scheme before the cut-off time on the record date) will be entitled to receive the IDCW.

Unit holders holding units in dematerialized (electronic) form whose names appear in the statement of beneficial owners maintained by the Depositories under the aforesaid schemes as at the close of business hours on **Monday, March 16, 2026** or immediately following Business Day will be entitled to receive the IDCW.

With regard to Unit holders under IDCW options of the aforesaid schemes, who have opted for IDCW Reinvestment facility, the IDCW due will be reinvested by allotting units for the IDCW amount (net of applicable taxes and stamp duty) (on the next Business Day

QUICKLY.

Aluminium rallies, focus on supply disruptions



London: Aluminium prices rallied on Wednesday as attention shifted to global supply losses from the Middle East conflict, following a brief sell-off triggered by comments from US President Donald Trump on the Iran war. Benchmark aluminium on the LME traded 1.1 per cent higher at \$3,442 a tonne. **REUTERS**

Gold eases as firmer \$, inflation concerns weigh

Gold prices edged lower weighed down by an uptick in the US dollar and looming inflation concerns that boosted the likelihood of higher interest rates. Spot gold was down 0.3 per cent at \$5,177.50 per ounce as of 1318 GMT. US gold futures for April delivery fell 1.1 per cent to \$5,185.20. Silver fell 3.1 per cent to \$85.67, and platinum lost 0.5 per cent to \$2,189.35. **REUTERS**

IEA set for record oil release from reserves



The International Energy Agency (IEA) has proposed the largest release of oil reserves in its history to restrain soaring crude prices amid the US-Israel war with Iran. The release would exceed the 182 million barrels of oil that IEA member nations put on the market in two releases in 2022. **REUTERS**

Indian Potash set to revive co-operative sugar mill in Odisha, invest ₹360 crore

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Indian Potash Ltd (IPL) plans to revive Odisha's Badamba Cooperative Sugar Mill, which has remained shut since 2010, with an investment of ₹360 crore. The company has signed a memorandum of understanding (MoU) with the Odisha government for the modernisation and expansion of the mill, IPL said in a statement.

ANOTHER MILL

The MoU was signed by IPL Managing Director PS Gahlaut and Odisha Cooperation Secretary Rajesh Prabhakar Patil during Union Cooperation Minister Amit Shah's visit to the State on March 6. At the event, Shah said another closed private sugar mill at Nayagarh in Khordha

Copper heads south on stronger \$, Iran war

PRICE RETREAT. The red metal has dropped below \$13,000 a tonne after soaring to \$14,500 in January

Subramani Ra Mancombu
Chennai

Copper prices have come under pressure on a stronger dollar, rising energy prices and the US-Israel war against Iran, according to analysts. "Copper prices have come under pressure in recent weeks as macro headwinds combine with softer physical demand signals," said ING Think, the economic and financial analysis wing of multinational financial services firm ING. Besides the macro issues, rising inventories on exchanges, increasing refined output in China and weaker Chinese import demand suggest that the tight market which supported prices in recent months may be starting to unwind, it said.

SHOR-TERM PRESSURE According to the Shanghai Metals Market (SMM), the macro transmission implies short-term downside pressure on copper prices.

"As the conflict drives oil prices higher, concerns about inflation and tighter monetary policy have increased, risk appetite has declined, and some speculative long positions have begun to unwind, putting pressure on copper prices," it said. Over the longer term, however, the copper market continues to face structural supply constraints, meaning that the current macro shock is more likely to manifest as sentiment-driven volatility rather than a fundamental reversal of the supply-demand trend, it said.

RECORD HIGH STOCKS All these are indicators of copper heading south. The red metal, used widely in construction, wiring, transport, industry and electric vehicles, dropped below \$13,000 a tonne to \$12,997 on the London Metal Exchange (LME). In January, it soared to \$14,500 a tonne (\$6.61 a pound on the COMEX, where the metal is down to \$5.81). ING Think said copper in-



BULL RUN FADES. Rising inventories, higher Chinese refined output and weaker import demand suggest that the market tightness, which is supporting prices, is easing

ventories on the Shanghai Futures Exchange recently hit a record high as physical demand softened in China. LME inventories are near a 17-month high. "The inventory build also reflects strong inflows into LME warehouses, driven by shifting regional pricing incentives. As the COMEX-LME spread narrows, the in-

centive to redirect metal to the US is fading," it said. As pricing signals normalise, the metal is being redirected back into LME warehouses and other exchange stocks, ING Think said, adding that the direction of SHFE stocks will be important to watch. A decline in inventories would suggest Chinese de-

India displaces China as largest exporter of cotton products to US

Vishwanath Kulkarni
Bangaluru

India has displaced China as the largest supplier of cotton products, such as apparel and home textiles, to the United States during 2025, according to the USDA's latest global market analysis. Factors such as higher tariffs and US firms' reducing dependence on China helped other suppliers, including India, gain market share in that country. US cotton product imports were flat in calendar year 2025 at 3.3 million

tonnes (mt), equal to the 15-year average. Imports from China went down to about 0.5 mt in 2025, while imports from India were around 0.6 mt during the year. **TARIFF IMPACT** The US had announced several rounds of tariffs on China that ranged from 10 to 125 per cent. While other countries also had varying levels of tariffs applied throughout the year, they were less than half of the highest rate applied on China. These conditions allowed

India and other suppliers, such as Vietnam, Bangladesh, Pakistan, Mexico and Cambodia, to expand market share in the US, the USDA said. Further, the USDA said India benefited from vertically integrated textile supply chains that enhance firms' ability to comply with traceability standards. In contrast, firms have been lessening their dependence on China due to the Uyghur Forced Labour Prevention Act (UFLPA) and the perception of increasing geopolitical risk, which has expanded to include tariff un-

certainty. US cotton product imports from China have dropped 60 per cent since peaking in 2010. **US IMPORTS TO SOAR** The US is the largest importer of cotton products. Though imports were flat, the retail sales at clothing stores in the US are estimated to have risen 5 per cent to a new record, the USDA said. Despite strong consumer demand, flat imports suggest that retailers drew inventories lower to minimise costs related to the fluid tariff environment.

During 2026, the imports of US cotton products are expected to rise because of low retailer inventories and stable consumer demand, the USDA said. Changing trade policies will continue to influence where these products are sourced from. Further, the USDA said the global production for 2025-26 is forecast up 1.1 million bales (of 480 pounds each) to 121 million bales on higher crops in Brazil and China. Global consumption is forecast down more than 0.1 million bales to 118.6 million

as reduced demand in Pakistan, Bangladesh, Mexico and Vietnam more than offset the higher demand in China. Global trade was raised by 0.2 million bales to 43.9 million on higher exports from Australia. Higher imports by India offset the lower imports by Pakistan, Bangladesh and Vietnam. Global ending stocks were raised nearly 1.3 million bales to 76.4 million as higher ending stocks in India and Brazil more than offset the lower ending stocks in Australia and Argentina.

Centre clears Telangana's buy of 1.25 lt of rabi crops

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

The Agriculture Ministry has approved procurement of over 1.25 lakh tonnes of 2026 rabi season crops in Telangana at the minimum support prices (MSP). The procurement will be done under the price support scheme (PSS). The process will include the procurement of 29,860 tonnes of gram, 37,020 tonnes of urad, 55,285 tonnes of groundnut and 3,690 tonnes of sunflower. The total value of these approvals, given by Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh, will be over ₹894 crore, an official statement said. The Centre aims to protect farmers from market fluctuations, ensuring they get full price for their hard work, Chouhan said.

Half of Maharashtra sugar mills may stay shut next season, says Minister

Our Bureau
Pune

More than half of Maharashtra's sugar mills may remain closed in the next crushing season due to a possible shortage of sugarcane and rising financial stress in the industry, State Cooperation Minister Babasaheb Patil told the Legislative Council on Tuesday. The Minister said drought-like conditions expected in the coming kharif season could significantly reduce cane availability, threatening the viability of many mills across the State. This season, 210 sugar mills, including 103 cooperative and 107 private mills, are operational in the State. Patil pointed out that the economics of the sugar sector had become increasingly strained in recent years. While the fair and remuner-

ative price (FRP) for sugarcane has been raised six times over the past six years, the minimum selling price (MSP) of sugar has remained unchanged at ₹31 per kg since 2019. "This mismatch between cane prices and sugar prices is putting severe pressure on mill finances," he said. **HEAVY INVESTMENT** The situation has been compounded by capacity expansion undertaken by several mills in recent years. Many units have invested heavily in increasing crushing capacity and setting up facilities to produce byproducts such as ethanol. However, the Minister noted that mills typically need to operate for at least 150 days in a season to recover administrative and operational costs, while most mills are currently running for barely 90 days. Patil also highlighted the

statutory obligation of mills to pay the FRP to farmers, regardless of market conditions. To meet these payments, several sugar factories have been forced to borrow from banks and financial institutions. **WEAK DEMAND** Weak domestic demand for sugar and restrictions on sales are further aggravating the sector's problems. Mills are currently receiving limited sales quotas in the domestic market, affecting their cash flows. Although many sugar mills in Maharashtra have the capacity to produce ethanol from B-heavy molasses, the State has been allotted only about 20 per cent quota for ethanol production, the Minister said. The State government plans to approach Union Cooperation Minister Amit Shah to seek an increase in the ethanol quota.

ICAR to host 3-day global meet on women in agri-food system from today

Our Bureau
New Delhi

President Droupadi Murmu on Thursday will inaugurate a three-day global conference on women in agri-food systems in New Delhi, organised by the Indian Council of Agricultural Research (ICAR), in association with the Trust for Advancement of Agricultural Sciences (TAAS) and the Protection of Plant Varieties and Farmers' Rights Authority (PPV&FRA). Briefing the media, ICAR's Director General M L Jat said that representatives of as many as 20 countries had confirmed their participation, though 35 countries had earlier shown interest to take part. Some of the countries have expressed their inability

to attend due to the current war in the Gulf and disruption in air travel in the West Asia region. With the theme 'Driving Progress, Attaining New Heights', the event aligns with the UN-declared International Year of the Woman Farmer (IYWF) 2026, spotlighting their vital roles in agri-food systems, ICAR said in a statement. The conference is also supported by the Consultative Group for International Agricultural Research (CGIAR) institutions. **STRENGTHENING POLICY FRAMEWORK** "The primary goal is to deliberate on strengthening policy frameworks and ecosystems to mainstream gender participation and highlight the indispensable role of women in building

sustainable and inclusive agri-food systems," Jat said. The three-day event will focus on sharing inspiring success stories of women leaders and scientists, and on integrating gender-sensitive approaches into agricultural policies and institutions. It will also examine entrepreneurship, financial models and market linkages to strengthen women's roles in value chains, besides deliberating on digital tools, climate-smart innovations and women-friendly technologies designed to boost productivity and reduce drudgery, the statement said. The conference will also host dedicated forums, including a Women Farmers' Forum to address grassroots challenges and a Youth Forum to engage and network with the next generation of agri-food leaders.

'US, Chile walnuts entering India via under-valued invoices'

Subramani Ra Mancombu
Chennai

Walnuts continue to be imported into India with under-valued invoices despite the Department of Revenue Intelligence (DRI) taking action in the recent past, industry sources said. Such undervalued imports are affecting the lives of marginal farmers in Jammu and Kashmir, the sources, speaking on the condition of anonymity, told *businessline*. "Recently, Chilean walnuts, for example, were imported at an undervalued \$1.2 per kg against the actual rates of \$3.5-4.5. The undervaluation is causing huge losses to the exchequer, apart from affecting small growers in Jammu and Kashmir," said a senior industry source. These details come at a time when the Customs De-



RINGFENCING FARMERS. The domestic industry is seeking a per kg duty on the nuts to safeguard J&K growers' interests

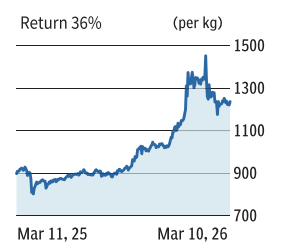
partment has begun releasing the containers it detained following information that walnut consignments were being imported by faking their origins. The walnuts were claimed as Afghan produce, when they are reported to be from China, to claim duty-free benefits under the South Asian Free Trade Agreement (SAFTA).

Jammu and Kashmir farmers being affected by the imports of under-invoiced walnuts. Sources said the Centre increased the tariff for imports of walnuts — the main horticulture produce in the northern region — to 100 per cent in 2018, mainly to protect small farm holders. Jammu and Kashmir produces 2.8 lakh tonnes of walnuts annually. The sector provides direct employment to 50 lakh women who shell walnuts during winter, when

there are no other employment opportunities. Sources said the 100 per cent import duty had led traders to wrongly claim benefits under SAFTA by making false claims on the origin of the produce. They said walnuts are not grown on organised orchards but by marginal farmers on small land holdings. These farmers depend mainly on the sales of their cash crop. **SMALL GROWERS** Walnut growers in Kashmir are also not organised like the raisin (grape) growers in Maharashtra. They don't have a collective voice. As a result, while raisin growers have been able to safeguard their interests, Kashmir walnut growers face unfair competition, the sources said. Going by the current prices of Chilean and US walnuts, the duty component translates to ₹270 and ₹225 a

kg respectively. Thus, a walnut grower in Kashmir could face a price cut of ₹225 at least, indirectly. "It also leaves a huge margin for unscrupulous importers to dictate terms in the market," said the senior industry source. Given the crop size in J&K, the loss could be pegged at ₹6,700 crore to the growers there, he said. The sources said one way to check under-invoicing could be by imposing a per kg basis duty, as is being done in the case of almonds. In September 2023, the Centre imposed a duty of ₹35 a kg for imported almonds in shell and ₹100 a kg for kernels. Such a decision will provide the much-needed cushion to the marginal farmers in Jammu and Kashmir, the sources said, adding that a fall in global prices would not affect revenue to the government.

COMMODITY CALL. Retain the short trade in copper



Akhil Nallamuthu
bl. research bureau

Copper futures are now trading at ₹1,207 a kg. For the past three weeks, the contract has traded largely in a sideways trend. The March contract has been oscillating between ₹1,172 and ₹1,220. Nevertheless, the price has been below the 21-day moving average, indicating a negative bias for the contract. Also, copper futures have remained below the key level of ₹1,250 for over a month now. Therefore, as of now, there is a bearish bias. The bears are likely to gain traction and eventually drag the price lower. From the current level of ₹1,207, the nearest support is at ₹1,172, followed by another one at ₹1,150.

On the other hand, if copper futures rally from the current levels and surpass the hurdle at ₹1,250, the outlook could turn bullish. In such a scenario, the contract could rally to ₹1,300. Overall, as it stands, the key resistance levels are valid, and so traders can remain on the short side of the trade.

TRADE STRATEGY Retain the short copper futures (March) that we suggested at ₹1,230. Maintain the stop-loss at ₹1,260. When the contract slips to ₹1,170, tighten the stop-loss to ₹1,210. Book profits at ₹1,150.

India may attract GCC investments if expansion in W. Asia slows amid tensions

STRONG POINTS. The advantage lies in the scale of skilled talent pool, mature ecosystem and cost efficiencies

Sanjana B
Bengaluru

India is poised to benefit from incremental investments in the global capability centre (GCC) ecosystem if geopolitical tensions slow expansion in West Asia, according to industry experts. India is already the world's largest GCC hub, with over 1,850 centres employing nearly 2 million professionals. The country's GCC sector generates around \$64-65 billion in annual revenue. In comparison, the West Asia market is valued at about \$4.2 billion in 2024 and is projected to reach nearly \$24.7 billion by 2032, according to TeamLease Digital. This is driven by government-led digital transformation and economic diversification initiatives. Within the region, the UAE accounts for about 27.6 per cent of the



MAJOR CONTRIBUTOR. India's GCC sector generates around \$64-65 billion in annual revenue

West Asia and Africa GCC market, supported by business-friendly free zones and strong global trade connectivity. "If expansion plans in West Asia slow down due to regional tensions, India's mature ecosystem, deep talent pool, and proven delivery capabilities will naturally attract a share of that investment," Neeti Sharma, CEO, TeamLease Digital, commented. Typically, geopolitical uncertainty sometimes makes

companies review the pace, expansion, and location of new investments. In such situations, India could see some incremental interest because it already has a large and well-established GCC ecosystem. However, most multinational companies usually follow a diversified location strategy rather than shifting entirely, so any advantage for India is likely to be gradual rather than immediate, Jaspreet Singh, Partner, Grant Thornton Bharat, explained.

India's advantage lies in the scale of its skilled talent pool, mature ecosystem, and cost efficiencies. The country already hosts around 55 per cent of the world's GCCs, and with the sector growing at about 10 per cent CAGR toward a \$110 billion market. While West Asia has a smaller talent pool locally compared to India, companies are attracted to the region due to its strategic location, connectivity, infrastructure, and business-friendly policies, including free zones and tax incentives. These advantages made countries like the UAE and Saudi Arabia ideal for regional headquarters, shared services, and market-facing operations serving Europe, Asia, and Africa, Sharma added. **NO CHANGES, FOR NOW** On the other hand, Mohammed Faraz Khan, Partner at Zinnov, argued that

the ongoing conflict in West Asia has not triggered immediate structural changes in GCC strategy. Enterprises with regional headquarters and capability centres in the Gulf are adopting a cautious, wait-and-watch approach rather than making short-term relocation decisions. "The region is still regarded as a well-developed business environment with strong infrastructure and established security frameworks. Currently, there is no evidence of large-scale exits or abrupt investment reversals," he said. Most organisations operate with robust business continuity plans. With a significant proportion of GCC mandates digitally enabled and globally distributed, operational stability remains intact. For now, companies are reassessing risk exposure and pacing expansion carefully, and not redrawing their global capability footprint.

Modi launches ₹5,650-cr projects in TN

Press Trust of India
Tiruchirappalli

Prime Minister Narendra Modi inaugurated, dedicated and laid the foundation stone for multiple development projects across Tamil Nadu worth about ₹5,650 crore on Wednesday, and said these projects would create thousands of jobs. Clad in a traditional shirt and dhoti, Modi unveiled the projects. He said, "These projects are about infrastructure, for clean energy, petroleum-related manufacturing, highways, railways and rural roads. They will boost energy access, connectivity and create thousands of jobs for the youth of Tamil Nadu," he said. The Prime Minister flagged off two Amrit Bharat Express trains: the Nagercoil-Charlapalli Amrit Bharat Express and the Podanur (Coimbatore)-Dhanbad Amrit Bharat Express, two express trains: the Rameswaram -Mangaluru Express and the Tirunelveli-Mangaluru Express, and a new train service between Mayiladuthurai-Thiruvannamalai, strengthening rail connectivity between Tamil Nadu and other regions, including Telangana, Karnataka, Kerala and eastern India. Flanked by Union

Ministers Piyush Goyal and L. Murugan, AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami and BJP Tamil Nadu chief Nainar Nageshwaran, Modi laid the foundation stone for Bharat Petroleum Corporation Ltd's city gas distribution network in the Nilgiris and Erode districts at an investment of more than ₹3,680 crore.

DEVELOPED TN Modi said, "Our goal is to create a developed Tamil Nadu for a developed nation. The Central government is fully committed to the welfare of the people of Tamil Nadu."

TO ADVERTISE

PLEASE CONTACT

Chennai : 044 - 28576300

Coimbatore : 0422 - 2212572

Madurai : 0452 - 2528497

Trichy : 0431 - 2302801

Puducherry : 0413 - 2224111

thehindu **businessline.**

**KERALA LIVESTOCK DEVELOPMENT BOARD LTD.**
(A Govt. of Kerala Undertaking)
Gokulam, Pattom RD., Thiruvananthapuram - 695004, Ph: 0471-2440920, 2449138

Notice Inviting e-Tenders
for the supply of liquid Nitrogen
No. 5941/2026/Pt. Date: 09/03/2026
KLD Board invites e-Tenders for the supply of liquid Nitrogen to the various units of the Board for a period of Six months. Last date for the submission of e-tender online: 26/03/2026, 5 PM. For further details, log on to www.livestock.kerala.gov.in, e-tender portal: www.etenders.kerala.gov.in.
Sd/-, Managing Director

PM unveils ₹10,800-cr projects in Kerala, CM boycotts event

Our Bureau
Kochi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Wednesday launched multiple infrastructure and development projects worth over ₹10,800 crore in Kerala, amid a boycott of the function by Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan and other Ministers. State Ministers stayed away from the event following the omission of PWD Minister PA Mohammed Riyas from the inaugural function of the first stretch of the six-lane expansion of National Highway 66 in Kozhikode.

Ahead of the Prime Minister's inauguration of the highway expansion, Mohammed Riyas protested at Ramanattukara in Kozhikode, describing the exclusion of a State Minister from the event as a humiliation to the State.

KEY PROJECTS Among the key projects inaugurated were the ₹5,500-crore Polypropylene Unit at the BPCL Kochi Refinery, the six-lane Kozhikode Bypass, a 50-MW floating solar project at West Kallada in Kollam, three redeveloped railway stations under the Amrit Bharat Station Scheme, and the Shoranur-Nilambur



Prime Minister Narendra Modi addressing a public meeting in Ernakulam on Wednesday PTI

Road Railway Line Electrification Project. Speaking on the occasion, Modi said the unit at BPCL Kochi Refinery will have the capacity to produce four lakh tonnes per annum to support packaging, automotive com-

ponents, medical devices, textiles sectors and household products. While laying the foundation stone for the 50-MW floating solar project at West Kallada, Modi stressed the need to generate more power

to support various industrial sectors as India emerges as a manufacturing hub in AI and semiconductor industries. Clean and green energy will be essential to support this growth, he said, adding that the project will contribute to India's clean-energy goals and reinforce the country's commitment to a sustainable and low-carbon future. Kerala, with a large number of water bodies, holds great potential in floating solar power plants. He said the six-lane Thalappady-Chengala section of NH-66, built at a cost of over ₹2,650 crore, forms part of the Mumbai-Kanyakumari Economic Corridor.

TN seed fund invests ₹20 cr in Aheesa Digital

Sindhu Hariharan
Chennai

Tamil Nadu Infrastructure Fund Management Corporation (TNIFMC), a State government-backed investment management firm, is investing ₹20 crore in Chennai-based fabless semiconductor start-up Aheesa Digital Innovations Pvt Ltd. The investment firm is making this bet through its Tamil Nadu Emerging Sector Seed Fund (TNESSF). The funds will help Aheesa in its tape-out to commercialisation phases. Aheesa's flagship product, VIHAAN-I, is a RISC-V network 28 nm system-on-chip (SoC) targeting broadband and optical access networks, and is backed by MeitY's Design Linked Incentive (DLI) Scheme. The chip aims to deliver semiconductor self-reliance for 5G edge AI/IoT deployments, enabling domestic OEMs to cut import costs.



Krishna Chaitanya K, TNIFMC CEO, and Ganapathy SK, Head of Strategy & Partnerships-TNIFMC (5th and 6th from left)

With a team of 30 people, most of them in R&D, Aheesa's SoC is the brain of networking communication devices. "We have taped out the chip and are awaiting the samples from the global fab, which we will likely receive by the end of the second quarter of this calendar year," Sridharan Mani, Director and CEO, Aheesa Digital Innovation, said. "Subsequently, we will conduct more tests, trials and engage with prospective customers to commence

production in the first quarter of 2027," he added. **SELF RELIANCE** Based on RISC V core open standards, the technology is insulated from geopolitical risks. Mani noted that telecommunication equipment is an area where the government, too, is keen to achieve self-reliance. With the Government of India's DLI grant already in place and TNIFMC stepping in as an institutional backer, this will help strengthen

Aheesa to complete the development of Vihaan-I and begin its market expansion. TNIFMC noted that India's fiber broadband market was expanding rapidly but every optical network terminal device deployed in the country currently runs on imported silicon. "This scenario represents a significant dependency in critical digital infrastructure and billions of rupees flowing overseas annually for chips that could be designed and produced domestically," the investment firm said. Krishna Chaitanya K, Chief Executive Officer, TNIFMC, told *businessline* that TNESSF provides risk capital to companies in emerging sectors. "In line with the Tamil Nadu government's Tamil Nadu Semiconductor Mission 2030 and its vision, Aheesa represents the kind of bold, deep-technology innovation the TNESSF was established to support," he said.

Emami Agrotech targets ₹2,000 crore from HoReCa, B2B segments in 2-3 yrs

Our Bureau
Kolkata

Emami Agrotech, which is strengthening its presence in the hotels, restaurants, catering and institutional segment, is targeting a turnover of ₹2,000 crore from the HoReCa business over the next two to three years. The company, part of the ₹30,000 crore Emami Group, launched the "Healthy & Tasty - FOR CHEF" range for the HoReCa and B2B foodservice segment at AA-HAR 2026, the International Food & Hospitality Fair being held in New Delhi. "For Chef" features multiple variants of edible oils along with essential pantry ingredients such as whole, pure and blended spices,



fresh *chakki atta*, *maida*, *sooji*, *besan* and soya chunks. These are offered in larger pack formats tailored for professional kitchens and institutional consumption.

EXPAND PORTFOLIO The company also plans to expand the 'For Chef' portfolio with sauces, condiments, ready-to-cook and ready-to-eat products in the

next few months, it said in a release on Tuesday. Jayant Goenka, Director, Emami Group, said, "The HoReCa segment represents a large and rapidly expanding consumption ecosystem with significant business potential. With the launch of our 'Healthy & Tasty - For Chef' range, we are strengthening our focus beyond retail." "Our portfolio - ranging from high-performance edible oils to essential pantry ingredients such as fresh *chakki atta*, *maida* and spices - is designed to support chefs and food service partners in delivering excellence at scale," he said. With a turnover of around ₹20,000 crore, the company is a leading player in India's edible oil industry.

Matex doubles B2B e-auction deals to ₹8,000 cr

T E Raja Simhan
Chennai

Matex Technologies, the Chennai-based B2B e-auction platform, has seen the value of auctions facilitated on its platform double to about ₹8,000 crore annually over the last three years. Companies use the platform to buy and sell a wide range of products, including scrap. Driven by these additions and increased client activity, the company's gross merchandise value rose from ₹4,212 crore in 2023 to ₹8,000 crore now, he said. "As companies balance compliance, profitability and growth, Matex platforms simplify processes through practical digital solutions," KE Ranganathan, Director, Matex Technologies, said.

**MADRAS MANAGEMENT ASSOCIATION**
ESTD. 1956

**WMF**
WOMEN MANAGERS' FORUM

MADRAS MANAGEMENT ASSOCIATION PRESENTS
MMA WOMEN MANAGERS' CONVENTION 2026
WOMEN LEADING
WITH PURPOSE, POWER & GENEROSITY
14 MARCH 2026, SATURDAY, 9:30 AM - 1:50 PM
MMA MANAGEMENT CENTER

**Mridula Ramesh**
Executive Director
Sundaram Textiles Ltd

**Babita Baruah**
Chief Executive Officer
VMI India

**Anu Hasan**
Artist & Entrepreneur

**Lakshmi Narayanan**
Whole-time Director
T Stanes & Co

**Dr Ranjini Manian**
Founder Chair,
Global Adjustments Foundation

**Radhe Jaggi**
Bharatanatyam Artist

**Tanvi Shah**
Singer, lyricist and winner, The Grammys

**Vishakha Hari**
Carnatic Vocalist & Harikatha Exponent

**Chitra Shah**
Founder, Satya Special School & VP, Special Olympics Bharat Board

**Vilasini Subramaniam**
Founder
The V-Women Project

**Jayashree Sundaresan**
Vice President
Freshworks

**San Lir Ramita Choudhary**
Indian Air Force (IAF) Qualifier, Ironman 70.3 Goa

**Charvi Anilkumar**
Chess Champion (Juniors)

**Dr Manasa Devi Rajkumar**
Dermatologist
Elidify

**Dr Suba P**
Dermatologist
Elidify

**Dr Sandhya Shekhar**
Convention Chairperson,
Independent Director

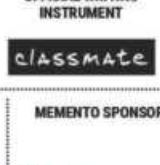
**Lakshminarayanan D**
Managing Director
Sundaram Home Finance Ltd

**M P Surya Prakash**
Executive Director
Pon Pure Chemicals

**Gp Capt R Vijayakumar**
(Retd), VSM
Executive Director, MMA

For Registration please contact Gp Capt Dr R Venkataraman (Retd) @ 94447 00068 / R Sundar - @ 98401 23906

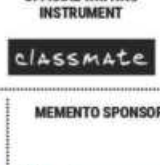
CO-SPONSORS


ASSOCIATE SPONSORS


MEDIA PARTNERS


PARTNER IN EXCELLENCE


PRIZE SPONSOR


OFFICIAL WRITING INSTRUMENT


GIFT HAMPERS


ACADEMIC SPONSOR


PARTNERS


MEMENTO SPONSOR






A CH-CHE

CM
Y
K

Exchange Traded Funds						
Company	Pre Cl	NSE Cl	Vol	52 WH	52 WL	BSE Cl
ONEAMC - GOLD360	155.80	156.06	399.11	378.08	78.20	-
ONEAMC - SILVER360	268.63	275.18	57.24	358.00	77.00	-
ONEAMC - AONEGLD36	14.92	14.95	498.50	17.73	10.00	-
ONEAMC - AONESILV36	10.25	10.08	81.14	12.00	9.70	-
ONEAMC - AONESMTQ50	9.57	9.38	89.17	10.50	8.00	-
ONEAMC - AONEOTETAL	11.27	11.25	11.51	11.21	0.63	-
ONEAMC-LIQ	1050.10	1050.21	16.87	1060.00	908.58	-
ONEAMC-NIF	9.94	9.79	1063.14	12.00	9.47	-
Gold 1	1331.10	1323.65	91.12	149.95	68.00	133.65
ONEAMC - AISVALUET	42.66	33.79	60.22	94.97	22.84	-
ONEAMC - AISVALUET	585.3	571.68	484.16	647.82	400.00	-
ONEAMC - AISVSESTF1	13.24	13.24	2.88	14.50	12.10	-
ONEAMC - AISVSESTF	113.94	111.88	7.79	131.85	104.55	-
ONEAMC - AISVSESTF	151.87	0.67	151.99	156.13	122.21	-
ONEAMC - AISVSESTF	265.68	361.65	1132.03	390.01	86.48	-
ONEAMC - AISVSESTF	321.37	324.75	3.21	439.67	323.57	-
ONEAMC - AISVSESTF	80.62	76.44	6.24	91.35	74.00	-
ONEAMC - AISVSESTF	159.89	199.49	52.92	180.16	127.96	-
ONEAMC - AISVSESTF	268.21	262.13	34.48	389.00	80.00	-
ONEAMC - AISVSESTF	588.52	576.13	1072.37	389.04	480.00	576.23
ONEAMC - AISVSESTF	154.75	155.55	106.45	184.05	82.00	-
TATAAMSLV	26.01	25.51	119263.16	35.10	8.56	-
TATAMIL - TNDTF	79.56	78.45	102.26	103.26	76.95	-
UTIAMC - BANKBETA	156.55	156.55	6.45	177.00	82.00	-
UTIAMC - GILT10BETA	58.77	57.54	91.69	73.30	48.71	-
UTIAMC - GILT10BETA	26.04	26.06	0.33	26.99	24.85	-
UTIAMC - GILTSBETA	65.18	65.11	2.40	66.37	60.09	-
UTIAMC - ITB81	313.81	313.81	0.99	410.00	308.77	-
UTIAMC - MIDCAPETA	212.61	212.45	0.98	235.48	178.10	-
Zerod High100	10.56	10.44	2931.67	12.00	7.66	-
Zerod Mid150	10.43	10.26	2425.28	11.57	8.01	-
ZerodAMC-LIQ	113.96	113.98	17436.49	113.10	102.00	-
ZerodAMSLM10	9.36	9.29	1491.37	11.08	8.80	-
Zerodhaa.GF	25.15	25.27	7593.35	27.94	12.83	-
Zerodhaa.NG	30.02	30.03	98.95	30.52	28.71	-
Zerodhaa.NG	27.42	26.70	12420.75	28.01	9.00	-
Zerodhaa.NG	9.68	9.53	4816.55	10.97	9.45	-

*: Closing price is the average of trade price(s) for the last half an hour; 52-Week High/Low figures pertain to BSE.

Shares of face value other than ₹10 is indicated in brackets immediately following the name of the company.

Qty (No of shares traded) is denoted in thousands.

The PE (price-earnings multiple) of each stock is based on the latest declared earnings.

The PE computation takes into account the per share earnings of each company for the latest 12 months.

[illegible]